

A Handful of Dust



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF EVELYN WAUGH

Evelyn Waugh was born in 1903, the second son in a family whose ancestry drew from throughout the British Isles as well as France. Evelyn's father Arthur, a publisher and literary critic of note, always favored his older son Alec, and their tight relationship habitually left the young Evelyn feeling shunned. In his schoolboy years Evelyn was something of a bully, and this instinct toward cruelty would stay with him throughout his adult life and frequently color his writings. Waugh attended Oxford, where he behaved rambunctiously, experimented with homosexuality, and developed a drinking problem that would follow him his whole life. He came close but ultimately failed to earn a degree. After college, he chose to become a writer and sparked a sensation with his first few novels: these mercilessly satirized the chic scene in interwar London to which he himself belonged, popularly referred to as the "bright young things." Following a disastrous first marriage and growing dissatisfaction with what he saw as a debased modern world, Waugh converted to Catholicism in 1930. Catholic themes, and the clash of tradition and modernity, would remain central to most of his work thereafter—much to the disappointment of some fans of his earlier satires. In the 1930s, he visited far-flung regions as a travel writer. He chose to fight in WWII when the time came, subsequently writing a trilogy of novels about the war. He continued to write, sometimes to great acclaim, until his death in 1966. However, his later years were marked by premature health issues and alcoholic decline, along with increasing bitterness towards the modern world. Today, his reputation stands firm as one of the 20th century's greatest English novelists and prose stylists.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

A Handful of Dust drew heavily on Waugh's recent personal experiences at the time of its writing. Waugh married his first wife, also named Evelyn (Gardner), in 1928, but the marriage lasted only a year before she declared that she loved John Heygate, her and Waugh's mutual friend. While finalizing their divorce, Waugh was also preparing to be received into the Roman Catholic Church, which he did in 1930. Flailing in the humiliating collapse of his marriage and subsequent disappointing sexual affairs, Waugh fled his problems on a journey to South America, where he intended to arrive at the remote Amazonian city of Manaus. This ultimately proved impossible, and he spent much time in boredom and discomfort in the jungle with little to read. During this time, he met an eccentric elderly man named Christie, who told Waugh of his

biblical visions. Christie ultimately became the model for Mr. Todd, and the entire experience, together with the marital breakdown and humiliation that preceded it, became the close autobiographical model for *A Handful of Dust*, which Waugh wrote between Morocco and England upon his return. Thus the seemingly incongruous, even unbelievable, third act of the novel in fact had its roots directly in Waugh's recent activities. The implicit critique of a wayward and debased secular society that the novel offers reflects Waugh's embrace of Catholicism, a pointed move in a country with centuries of Catholic-Protestant tensions.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Waugh's first two novels, *Decline and Fall* and *Vile Bodies*, were scathing and uproarious satires of the interwar London social circle he ran in. *A Handful of Dust* is often considered Waugh's crucial transitional book, since it retains the merciless and often funny depictions of contemporary London socialites that he had become known for, but humor is not as much of a priority. Instead, a deeper critique of modern civilization—reflecting his conversion to Catholicism—enters the novel, a critique that would come to dominate his later work more and more. Highlights of this more serious later period include [Brideshead Revisited](#), often called one of the best novels of the century, and the *Sword of Honour* trilogy, derived from his time fighting in WWII. Waugh's clique that he satirized in *A Handful of Dust* were known as the "Bright Young Things," and among their ranks were other noted novelists including Henry Green, author of similarly autobiographical novels like *Party Going*, and crime novelist Dorothy Sayers, whose popular works included *Murder Must Advertise*. Waugh's title and epigraph for this novel were taken from T.S. Eliot's poem *The Waste Land*, which similarly reflected on the crisis of faith and meaning in modernity and is often considered the century's most significant poem. The Amazonian misadventure in *A Handful of Dust* alludes to Joseph Conrad's 1899 novella [Heart of Darkness](#), which similarly follows a harrowing journey up a jungle river and confrontation with madness. Conrad was also a significant influence on Eliot, so Waugh's evocation of them both was intended to place himself in a recent literary tradition.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** A Handful of Dust
- **When Written:** 1933-1934
- **Where Written:** England and Morocco
- **When Published:** 1934
- **Literary Period:** Modern

- **Genre:** Novel, Satire
- **Setting:** 1930s England; Amazon rainforest
- **Climax:** Tony realizes he is stuck reading to Mr. Todd forever.

EXTRA CREDIT

Alternate Ending. The episode with Mr. Todd was actually written first as a short story and published in an American newspaper. When Waugh incorporated it into the novel, he couldn't publish it in the United States due to a copyright dispute, so he had to write an alternate ending for the American edition, in which Tony happily returns to England and reunites with Brenda!

Highly Ranked. *A Handful of Dust* was one of three novels by Waugh to make the Modern Library's respected list of the 100 best novels of the 20th century—the others being *Scoop* and *Brideshead Revisited*. Waugh is one of just seven writers to have that many works on the list.



PLOT SUMMARY

In 1930s London, John Beaver is an unemployed 25-year-old Oxford graduate living at home with his mother, Mrs. Beaver. John is a charmless and unimpressive young lad, who spends his days looking to score a free lunch from among the London socialite crowd whose ranks he is eager to ascend. Widely regarded as a social climber and pest, John is nonetheless tolerated at gatherings when more desirable guests can't be found. Mrs. Beaver is a ruthless interior decorator who keenly assists her son's lackluster social climbing efforts. John has fastened onto a passing and insincere invite from Tony Last to **Hetton**, his country estate, for the weekend, and he intentionally telegrams of his imminent arrival with too little time for the invite to be revoked.

At **Hetton**, Tony Last surveys the deteriorating neo-Gothic décor of his beloved ancestral home, and he and his slightly younger wife Brenda Last read the morning mail. Tony dismisses all social invites they receive, preferring never to leave Hetton or host guests, despite Brenda's desire for company. Their young son John Andrew learns horse jumping from the stable master Ben Hackett, whom the boy loves but whose gruff influence on the child disturbs his prim nanny. Being a member of the landed gentry, Tony lives comfortably on passive income and passes his time in the same small circuit of local routines, like going to church—despite his lack of interest in religion. The sudden news of Beaver's arrival horrifies Tony, who knows him only in passing as a freeloading pest, and he plans to make Beaver's stay as uncomfortable as possible to ensure his quick departure. When he arrives, Brenda steps up

to entertain him while Tony flees to various chores. To her surprise, she and Beaver hit it off and have a nice weekend apart from the awkwardness Tony imposes. Brenda relishes hearing updates from Beaver on London gossip and her old socialite crowd. After Tony gives Beaver a proud tour of Hetton, Brenda admits to Beaver that she detests the house but hides her feelings from Tony.

On a day trip to her sister Marjorie's in London, Brenda admits that she's romantically interested in Beaver. Running into him again while discussing the rental of a London flat from Mrs. Beaver, Brenda eventually convinces Beaver to escort her to Polly Cockpurse's upcoming party, a major social event. Beaver successfully kisses Brenda on the way to the party. Their dalliance has already become the talk of the town the next day, and it soon becomes a real affair. Beaver enjoys increased social clout from the affair, which his mother strongly endorses, while Brenda annoys Tony and disappoints John Andrew by returning days late to Hetton. She promptly goes to work wearing down Tony to agree to rent her one of Mrs. Beaver's London flats. He caves in, and soon Brenda is **telephoning** him from the flat to gush about it while John Beaver lies beside her in bed. Over Christmas, Tony's poorer relatives, the family of Richard Last, come to visit Hetton and discomfit Brenda with their earthy ways. Brenda fears Beaver has lost interest in her. Tony unexpectedly accompanies her to a friend's house over New Year's, and Beaver is also a guest there. He and Brenda intentionally steer clear of each other, but Brenda then tells Tony she will start economics courses as a pretext to spend more time in London.

Tony goes to London one evening to surprise Brenda, but she can't be reached. He runs into his old friend Jock Grant-Menzies, who has also been stood up. The two drink heavily together as Tony becomes morose about Brenda's increasing absence from Hetton. They go on a drunken spree, and Tony makes several drunken **phone** calls to Brenda's flat, where Beaver is with her. Jock, who knows about the affair like the rest of London, helps divert Tony. Tony's hungover shame the next day allows Brenda to become more flagrant in her disrespect for Tony: she invites Polly and other ruthless friends to Hetton, where they mock the house and Tony's dull habits. Fearing that she's gone too far, Brenda attempts to arrange for her apartment neighbor Jenny Abdul Akbar, a crass American widow, to seduce Tony and take the pressure off her own affair. Tony despises Jenny and her visit to Hetton fails spectacularly, though John Andrew does fancy her.

The day of the annual Hetton fox hunt arrives, eagerly awaited by John Andrew, who is reluctantly permitted to ride along. Jock and his austere girlfriend Mrs. Rattery join the hunting party. During a minor traffic jam, the villager Miss Ripon's unruly horse kicks and instantly kills John Andrew. Jock volunteers to deliver the news to Brenda, who skipped the hunt for a party in London, while Mrs. Rattery stays to keep company

with the quietly distraught Tony. She and Tony play cards to distract him while Jock tracks Brenda down to a fortune-telling party at Polly's. Brenda at first can't process Jock's news, but when she realizes that John Andrew and not John Beaver was the one who died, she blurts out "Oh thank God," later claiming that she was delirious when she said it. Brenda returns to Hetton, where Tony is ordering affairs, but she quickly leaves again to a friend's for the weekend, where Beaver is. She declares her love for Beaver, and telegrams Tony the same, saying she will not return to Hetton. Tony is stupefied, and Jock must reveal that everyone but Tony has known about the affair.

Tony spends a few weeks at Jock's as he processes the shock. Intermediaries inform him of Brenda's satisfaction with the fair sum of 500 pounds annual alimony, but due to divorce laws of the time, Tony must collect "evidence" of his own adultery for the split to proceed. He arranges a weekend at Brighton, a seaside resort, with Milly, a prostitute he and Jock met during their drunken night out. Detectives follow him to collect staged "evidence," but Milly unexpectedly brings along her horrible young daughter Winnie, threatening the whole conceit. The weekend is awkward. Back in London, Brenda's brother Reggie meets with Tony and reveals that with this new evidence, she will in fact demand 2000 pounds alimony. Shocked and disillusioned, Tony recalls that Winnie's presence voids the alleged evidence and counters that he will give Brenda nothing. Brenda's friends are shocked by the news.

Feeling he needs a break from Hetton in the wake of the recent upheavals, Tony spontaneously joins the eccentric explorer Dr. Messenger's voyage seeking a lost city in the Amazon. Onboard the transatlantic crossing, he sparks up a romance with a young, mysterious Trinidadian girl, Therese de Vitre. Tony's offhand mention of his marriage sours the affair, and she soon disembarks. Arriving in South America, he and Dr. Messenger assemble supplies and start upstream, with Tony increasingly harried by the harsh jungle environment. They reach an Indian village, where the English-speaking Rosa acts as interpreter and helps them organize a team of Indians to guide their quest for the city. They travel inland for weeks, getting progressively more lost in the jungle. The natives build canoes for Dr. Messenger but refuse to accompany them any further, and Messenger's incompetent negotiations scare them away, leaving him and Tony alone. After a few days of downstream drifting, Tony gets a violent fever and begins hallucinating Brenda's presence. Messenger leaves him on shore and rows on in search of help, but he dies in a waterfall. Totally alone, Tony's hallucinations overtake him in a terrifying blend of random incidents from earlier in the novel. Meanwhile, back in London, Brenda and Beaver's relationship sours as her money dries up; Beaver leaves her to go to California with his mother, and her friends abandon her.

Still delirious, Tony stumbles onto the remote jungle ranch of Mr. Todd, a mixed-race English-speaking son of a missionary.

Mr. Todd nurses Tony back to health, but his care soon turns sinister: Mr. Todd loves the works of Dickens that line his walls, but he can't read, so he forces Tony to read to him endlessly—as he did to a previous visitor, whose grave is on the ranch. After several months, a search party comes looking for Tony, but Mr. Todd drugs Tony during their arrival and convinces them that Tony has died. Tony awakes, horrified at his last lifeline being severed and at his fate of having to read Dickens aloud forever.

With Tony presumed dead, Richard Last and his family have inherited **Hetton**, being Tony's closest relatives. They have economized by closing several wings, laying off staff, and introducing fox farming. After a dedication ceremony for a monument to Tony, Richard's son Teddy goes to tend to his foxes, whom he proudly views as the means to restore Hetton to its glory days as under his cousin Tony.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Tony Last – Tony Last is a member of the landed gentry in 1930s England. A little over 30 years old, Tony lives at **Hetton**, the ancestral country estate where he grew up, with his wife, Brenda Last, and their young son, John Andrew. Tony has lived a sheltered life at Hetton—he still sleeps in his childhood bedroom—and he remains profoundly devoted to the estate, even though the neo-Gothic style of its garish 1860s renovation has become repugnant to modern tastes. Unlike Brenda, Tony has no interest in London's glitzy social life. Doting on Hetton is his priority, and it blinds him to his younger wife's obvious boredom with the house and their isolated domestic existence there. Brenda's spontaneous affair with John Beaver thus catches him totally off guard. His basic lack of malice makes Brenda's betrayal almost beyond comprehension to him. At the same time, that lack of malice is simply a luxury of his pampered, unreflective existence. He was ensured at birth—and has happily embraced—a life of bland, pleasant rituals, detached from the traditional moral and religious values they once encoded. His naïve "habit" of trust is so strong that he willingly collects evidence against himself during his divorce proceedings with Brenda, trusting her verbal assurance of a fair alimony request and not recognizing her clearly extortionate plans. When this last illusion crumbles, Tony's resulting moment of clarity provokes his life's first act of real agency, rejecting Brenda's demands and boldly throwing in with the eccentric Dr. Messenger's journey through the Amazon. But what feels to Tony like boldness is really just nihilistic recklessness, dooming himself on a random whim that requires no more authentic valor than his deluded existence at Hetton.

Brenda Last – Brenda Last is Tony Last's wife. Around 5 years younger than Tony, the attractive Brenda is still in her mid-20s and has grown bored with her isolated domestic existence at

Hetton, yearning for the glamorous London social life she once enjoyed. She still makes regular visits to her sister Marjorie in London, but generally she has lost touch with her old scene. John Beaver's chance arrival at Hetton reminds her of the life she has left behind, and she seizes on him as its avatar and falls madly in love with him, despite his lack of any appealing qualities. Brenda's betrayal of Tony for Beaver reveals her cruelty, shallow self-centeredness, and terrible judgment. Her infatuation with Beaver crowds out all the motherly affection owed to her and Tony's young son, John Andrew. Nevertheless, Waugh is unambiguous in his damning portrait of Brenda, who also suffers from the negative influence of her wretched new London friends. She represents the decay of traditional values that Waugh seeks to depict. It seems that she gets her comeuppance when Tony skirts her alimony extortion scheme to leave her penniless, and Beaver and her friends abandon her. The novel, however, reserves a final ironic twist for the epilogue, where Brenda ends up happily married to Jock Grant-Menzies, who was considered a likely match for her before she ever married Tony.

John Beaver – John Beaver is a 25-year-old unemployed Oxford graduate who lives at home with his mother, Mrs. Beaver. Widely disliked in the London socialite scene that he tries so doggedly to penetrate, Beaver is correctly judged a charmless social climber and freeloader with little personal value to offer. He is, however, tolerated as a last-resort invite to social events in need of seats filled. His shrewd and ambitious mother strongly encourages her lazy son to work his way up the social hierarchy. Beaver experiences a sudden, rapid social ascent when he unexpectedly steals the heart of Brenda Last. Beaver willingly uses Brenda to raise his stock among London socialites, who marvel at Brenda's unlikely choice of lover. When Brenda leaves Tony Last and fails to secure any alimony, however, Beaver callously but predictably abandons the now-destitute Brenda (like the rest of her friends) and leaves for California with his mother. Beaver's parasitic nature and lack of any ambition or interests beyond a free lunch render him an archetype of the valueless modern man that Waugh deplored.

Jock Grant-Menzies – Jock Grant-Menzies is a London socialite and member of Parliament. Jock is level-headed, good company, and universally well-liked. Once thought of as a potential match for Brenda Last before she ended up with Tony Last, he in fact does marry her in the novel's epilogue after Tony's disappearance and John Beaver's departure. Nevertheless, he seems to be one of the few people Tony considers a true friend. Jock accompanies Tony on his drunken spree in London, all while playing damage control to ensure Tony doesn't stumble onto evidence of Brenda's affair. Jock's interim girlfriend Mrs. Rattery joins him at **Hetton** for the disastrous fox hunt and keeps Tony company, while Jock goes to tell Brenda the news of John Andrew's death. After Brenda leaves Tony, Tony crashes at Jock's apartment for a few weeks.

There is no indication that Jock intended to take Tony's wife all along; Waugh includes this rather as a chance irony that provides symmetry to the novel, which began with Mrs. Beaver's remarks about Jock being a better fit for Brenda than Tony.

Mrs. Beaver – John Beaver's mother Mrs. Beaver is a widowed interior decorator and ruthless social operator. She keenly exploits every social opening to generate more business for herself, and she heavily assists her parasitic son's freeloading and social climbing maneuvers. She rents the flat to Brenda Last that Brenda uses for her trysts with John Beaver. Her venture to carve numerous small flats out of an old building, and totally redecorate them with heartless modern décor, epitomizes the baseness and hostility to tradition that Waugh intends to satirize.

John Andrew – John Andrew is the young son of Tony Last and Brenda Last. A passionate and curious child with an innocent lack of any filter on what he'll say, he adores horse jumping, which he practices with Ben Hacket. John Andrew likewise adores Ben, though the nanny and Tony worry about Ben's gruff working-class comportment influencing the boy. As Brenda loses interest in life at **Hetton**, Tony too becomes increasingly mentally preoccupied with his troubled marriage, and John Andrew thus receives diminishing attention from both parents. In a bitter irony, the great fox hunt which the boy so eagerly anticipated winds up getting him killed in a random accident.

Mrs. Rattery – Mrs. Rattery is Jock Grant-Menzies's girlfriend, whom he invites to join him at **Hetton** for the fox hunt. Before meeting her, Tony Last has already dubbed her the "shameless blonde," in apparent reference to some prior act. Contrary to his expectation of a gregarious airhead, however, Rattery is highly laconic and austere. She arrives at Hetton behind the wheel of a propeller plane, establishing the pattern of bold, masculine behavior that characterizes her. She is fond of extended games of solitaire. After John Andrew's death, Mrs. Rattery stays behind to keep Tony company while Jock delivers the news to Brenda. Mrs. Rattery's presence in the novel is mysterious, but Waugh certainly intends to contrast her honorable reserve with the shamelessness of Brenda and her friends, excepting her from the relentlessly negative characterization he applies to almost all the other women in the novel.

Dr. Messinger – Dr. Messinger is an eccentric explorer searching for a lost city in the Amazon, whose mission Tony Last joins on a whim. As Tony knows nothing about travel and survival, he entrusts himself to the apparently experienced Messinger, but as their Amazon journey progresses, Messinger's competence comes into question. His unwavering but misplaced confidence in his own understanding of the Amazonian natives causes them all to abandon him and Tony, essentially dooming their mission.

Mr. Todd – Mr. Todd, the English-speaking son of a missionary and an Amazonian native, runs the remote jungle ranch onto which Tony Last stumbles in his fevered delirium. Mr. Todd nurses the near-death Tony back to health, but his care takes on an increasingly sinister character as it becomes clear that he will not allow Tony to leave. Mr. Todd is a great lover of the Dickens novels his father left him, but he himself cannot read. A previous traveler was kept on his plantation and, it is implied, forced to read to him until he eventually died. At the novel's end, Tony now faces the same fate.

Rosa – Rosa is a Macushi woman who speaks English and acts as the interpreter between her people and Tony Last and Dr. Messinger. She attributes her English knowledge to having “live[d] bottom-side two years with Mr. Forbes,” an unexplained reference. She consistently demands cigarettes from Dr. Messinger, and she frustrates him and Tony by insisting that her people will not accompany them to the Pie-Wie territory and must turn back.

Polly Cockpurse – Polly Cockpurse is a ringleader among London gossips and socialites. She was ruthlessly successful as a social climber, ascending from obscurity into the center of the scene, marrying an earl along the way. Her party provides the occasion for Brenda Last and John Beaver's first romantic rendezvous. Polly is the first to hear of and spread the word of Brenda's affair with Beaver, and she aids Brenda in her effort to set up Jenny Abdul Akbar with Tony Last. Brenda is at Polly's house having her fortune told when she hears the news of John Andrew's death.

Jenny Abdul Akbar – Jenny Abdul Akbar is the American widow of a Moroccan prince, who lives in the flat next to Brenda Last's. Brenda tries to use Jenny to bait Tony Last into an affair—thereby taking the pressure off her own affair with John Beaver. Jenny is a vulgar and ridiculous character, constantly making histrionic references to her own suffering and cursed fate. Her attempted seduction of Tony fails spectacularly, although she does awaken erotic feelings in John Andrew, who becomes infatuated with her.

Mrs. Northcote – Mrs. Northcote is the fraudulent fortune teller at Polly Cockpurse's gathering, which Jock Grant-Menzies interrupts to inform Brenda of John Andrew's death. The ladies are each enraptured by Mrs. Northcote's mysterious and exciting fortune readings, but the reader soon finds out that she gives the same generic prediction to everyone. Waugh intended her character to exemplify the false prophets and idols to which people flock in the absence of religion.

Marjorie – Marjorie is Brenda Last's younger sister. Though lovely as well, she is “more solid than Brenda.” She and her husband Allan are popular but not rich, and they live in a small house in London. Brenda normally stays with them when she comes to town, until she gets her own flat. Marjorie consistently disapproves of Brenda's affair with the odious

John Beaver, though she is almost alone among London socialites in doing so.

Allan – Allan is Marjorie's husband and a prospective local political candidate in South London. He feigns ignorance of Brenda Last's affair when she mentions it to him. After Brenda leaves Tony Last, Allan exercises his diplomatic instincts and tries to act as peacemaker by going to each of them separately, lying to Tony that Brenda wants to reconcile, and likewise lying to Brenda that Tony will grant a divorce to avoid scandal. His ultimate plan with this is unclear beyond the desire to play diplomat, and Brenda justifiably writes him off as an “interfering ass.”

Reggie – Reggie St. Cloud is Brenda Last's oldest brother and an eccentric amateur archaeologist, a pursuit that has yielded various antiques but little financial reward. Oafish, “unnaturally stout,” and unaware of his own clumsiness, he is nevertheless called in to mediate between Brenda and Tony Last and deliver Brenda's extortionate alimony demands. Predictably bungling the interaction, Reggie instead agitates Tony into refusing alimony altogether, leaving Brenda out to dry.

Ben Hacket – Ben Hacket oversees the horses on **Hetton**'s grounds. A gruff and foul-mouthed member of the lower class, he earns the young John Andrew's adoration for teaching him how to jump horses and entertaining him with vulgar stories. His genuineness and simple, traditionally masculine virtues provoke John Andrew's admiration in a way that the boy's parents do not. After Richard Last and his family take over Hetton, Ben remains employed on the grounds and helps Teddy with fox-farming.

Nanny – John Andrew's nanny is a stern old killjoy who consistently decries John Andrew's innocently crass behavior and foul language, which she attributes to the influence of Ben Hacket. Nevertheless, her distaste for the grand **Hetton** foxhunt and wish to prevent John Andrew from participating prove prescient, given the disaster that occurs. Her concern for John Andrew is genuine, if unappreciated.

Mr. Tendril – Mr. Tendril is the local priest at the **Hetton** church, which Tony Last tries to attend every Sunday. Tendril was stationed in British colonial India many decades ago, and he still repeats the same sermons he wrote for that setting verbatim, to ridiculous effect. However, neither Tony nor the village parishioners mind the bizarre and incongruous sermons, to which they are long accustomed. Tendril's character highlights the church's failure to adapt to and address the pressing concerns of modern existence, preferring to live blithely in the past as its rites transform into a meaningless social ritual.

Miss Ripon – Miss Ripon is a villager near **Hetton**, whose unruly horse kicks and kills John Andrew on the day of the fox hunt. Miss Ripon had no business riding the difficult horse, which had thrown and injured her earlier that day, but her

father had been cynically trying to sell the horse for an unreasonable price and wanted to have it shown off. At the inquest, the traumatized Miss Ripon has to give evidence.

Milly – Milly is one of the two prostitutes, along with Babs, that Tony Last and Jock Grant-Menzies meet at the Old Hundredth club on the night of their drunken spree. She and Babs fail to secure Tony and Jock’s business on that night, but she later agrees to go with Tony to Brighton, helping him frame himself as an adulterer to secure his and Brenda’s divorce (due to the divorce laws of the time). She insists on bringing along her insufferable eight-year-old daughter Winnie, to Tony’s dismay. Her and Tony’s strained interactions throughout the weekend reveal Tony’s discomfort in dealing with people of a lower class, inadvertently insulting Milly.

Winnie – Winnie is Milly’s eight-year-old daughter. Brought along against Tony Last’s will on his and Milly’s weekend in Brighton, she threatens to derail the whole staged premise of an adulterous tryst. A relentless brat, her very vocal whining throughout the weekend makes Tony miserable at the time, but the unwanted attention it draws turns out to save him from Brenda’s extortion attempt by rendering the evidence of his “adultery” useless.

Thérèse de Vitré – Thérèse de Vitré is an 18-year-old Trinidadian girl aboard Tony’s transatlantic crossing. Her family, presumably aristocrats in France, came to Trinidad during the French Revolution and became part of the island’s small aristocratic elite, from among whom Thérèse, bound by custom, will eventually choose a husband. Thérèse and Tony Last strike up a brief romance during the voyage. She speaks the cold and formal English of a well-educated foreigner, and her personality is correspondingly opaque—ironically, since de Vitré is French for “made of glass.” Tony’s offhand mention of the fact that he’s still technically married sours their relationship, and Thérèse loses all interest in him, disembarking in Trinidad with hardly a goodbye.

Richard Last – Richard Last is Tony Last’s cousin, whose line of the family had been disinherited from **Hetton** by rite of primogeniture. Nevertheless, he and his rambunctious family still think of Hetton as their own when they come to visit Tony and Brenda at Christmas, making Brenda uncomfortable with their rustic, un-aristocratic ways. After Tony’s presumed death, Richard and his family are the closest living relatives and inherit the estate. He and his family happily move in, and he downsizes the staff and introduces fox farming on Hetton grounds to bring in extra cash.

Teddy – Teddy is Richard Last’s 22-year-old son. He lives with his family at **Hetton** once they move in. Teddy, with Ben Hackett’s help, eagerly takes to the fox-farming his family has introduced to Hetton grounds. The novel ends with Teddy proudly surveying the caged foxes, imagining that they will be the path towards “restor[ing] Hetton to the glory that it had

enjoyed in the days of his cousin Tony.” While this may seem like a rather unrealistic scheme, Waugh foreshadows the notion that Teddy carries Tony’s legacy forward when Jenny Abdul Akbar repeatedly mistakes Tony’s name as Teddy.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Mrs. Tipping – Mrs. Tipping is a London socialite who disappoints John Beaver by calling him just to ask for Jock Grant-Menzies’s contact information. When Jock declines to attend her luncheon, however, she calls Beaver again and invites him to the seat Jock declined, which he accepts.

Babs – Babs is the other prostitute with Milly that Tony Last and Jock Grant-Menzies meet at the Old Hundredth club during their drunken night on the town.

Dan – Dan is another guest at the Brighton resort where Tony Last takes Milly for a weekend of staged adultery. A previous client of Milly’s, he recognizes her and invites her and Tony to a raucous party, which they attend.



THEMES

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COMMUNICATION BREAKDOWN AND THE LOSS OF MEANING

Communication breakdown lies at the heart of *A Handful of Dust*. English landed gentry Tony and

Brenda’s marriage collapses because of a mutual failure to communicate: Brenda conceals her real feelings about **Hetton**, Tony’s ancestral estate (“[...] so appallingly ugly. Only I’d rather die than say that to Tony”), initially to protect Tony’s feelings, but her concealment breeds boredom and resentment that evolves into more malign deception in the form of her affair with John Beaver. For his part, Tony’s obliviousness to Brenda’s clearly dissatisfied behavior leaves him blindsided by the affair that everyone else in their scene finds obvious.

Yet the novel registers a communicative collapse that runs deeper than just an individual marriage. Waugh invokes this theme through the ubiquitous presence of the **telephone**. At the time Waugh was writing, the early 1930s, the telephone was still a relatively recent invention and had only just begun to become widespread in private homes. It’s important to keep this novelty in mind to appreciate the profound disruption in normal lines of communication that *A Handful of Dust* seeks to depict. Telephones both invade the privacy one formerly enjoyed at home and breed alienation by offering a cheap

substitute for human contact (“Why did you go all the way to London to telephone her?...Why, daddy?”). By creating distance in the illusory guise of nearness, Waugh implies, telephones increase “communication” while emptying it of meaning.

Ultimately, the telephone’s assault on communication merely symbolizes a deeper rupture: Brenda and Tony’s post-WWI generation have been cut off from their history and themselves. Through the deterioration of Brenda and Tony’s marriage and the generational alienation it reflects, Waugh suggests that rapid modernization has severed people’s line of contact with the past and accordingly blocked them off from the personal depths that such contact is meant to stir. People thus grow blunted, shallow, and cruel. Tony’s fate literalizes this total communicative collapse, trapped in a foreign jungle and without hope of contacting anyone who could help him.



RELIGION, MORALITY, AND TRADITION

Religion, morality, and tradition are notably absent from the lives of the characters in *A Handful of Dust*.

This conspicuous absence is precisely Waugh’s point in the novel, which seeks to portray the hollowness of a society where religion, morality, and tradition have lost their grip. Amoral and mendacious behavior dominates Brenda’s London social scene. Its status-obsessed members seem incapable of, and uninterested in, anything beyond ephemeral gossip and social climbing. Tony’s unoffending passivity may seem preferable to such active nastiness, but his behavior turns out to be nearly as shallow: having disingenuously offered John Beaver an invite to **Hetton**, he then tries to sabotage Beaver’s unexpected visit by shunning his duties as a host. This inhospitality violates the chivalric code embodied in Hetton’s Arthurian décor, and it exposes the frivolity of Tony’s make-believe existence within its walls. Though the imitation-Gothic surroundings let Tony think of himself as a descendent of the knights of medieval legend—who were the English aristocracy of their day—Tony has no conception of the stringent values by which they lived, only superficially aping them in his relative politeness.

Religion’s absence is the key to this woeful neglect of tradition and morality. For Waugh, religion is the ground from which morality springs. Accordingly, his vicious satire targets the rapidly secularizing modern world for its unthinking abandonment of any basis for traditional moral codes. The London milieu simply has no interest in religion whatsoever, and its degraded behavior naturally follows. Tony’s enthusiasm for churchgoing, by contrast, is just an equally empty social ritual: when the Hetton vicar Mr. Tendril tries to comfort Tony after John Andrew’s death, Tony says, “It was very painful... after all the last thing one wants to talk about at a time like this is religion.” Later, in the jungle, when Mr. Todd asks him if he believes in God, Tony replies, “I suppose so. I’ve never really thought about it much.” Tony’s blithe participation in “Christian”

social events without even wrestling with actual belief is just as hollow as the London scene’s openly amoral conduct.

Waugh, however, does not simply mean to finger-wag at the irreligious for their impiety. Mr. Tendril’s comic neglect of updating his sermons from 40 years ago in India, and his parishioners’ dopey acceptance of this irrelevant recycled product, encapsulates the Church’s failure to come to terms with modernity. Waugh takes seriously the crises of meaning in a rapidly technologizing world. In not rising to this challenge, the Church invites its own fate of becoming a meaningless social custom. In Waugh’s view, as religion recedes in the face of societal upheaval, the morality and tradition once grounded in it come toppling down. People accordingly become the way Waugh shows them in this book: weak, foolish, and depraved.



CHANCE AND FATE

Listless socialite Brenda is duped by fortune-tellers twice in *A Handful of Dust*: once in her first meeting with John Beaver, whose believably serious

opening quickly gives way to a ludicrous joke-fortune; and once by Mrs. Northcote, a foot-sole-reading scam artist who gives the same vague prophecy to all of Brenda’s friends. Brenda never discovers the sham behind Mrs. Northcote’s grave façade. Beaver’s reading, on the other hand, was a trivial prank meant to be exposed immediately, and yet it unwittingly contains a distorted but comprehensive account of the plot to come: “Oh yes... there is going to be a sudden death which will cause you great pleasure and profit. In fact you are going to kill someone. [...] then you are going to go on a long journey across the sea, marry six dark men and have eleven children, grow a beard and die.”

The recurrence of fortune-telling, and the random and improbable truthfulness of Beaver’s insincere prophecy, signal the importance of chance and fate in the novel. Tony’s disingenuous and immediately forgotten weekend invitation to Beaver sets in motion the end of his marriage. A motorcycle backfiring startles a horse and robs young John Andrew of his life. Random incidents with devastating consequences seem to control this world. In the novel’s last third, Tony reckons with his lifelong passivity and attempts to assert agency over his fate with a daring voyage to the Amazon—only to arrive at the most random and improbable doom imaginable, stuck reading to the illiterate Mr. Todd on his remote ranch. In Waugh’s vision, earthly life’s seemingly incomprehensible brutality is a fact that societies have lived with forever, in the face of which religion traditionally provided comfort, guidance, and meaning. For Waugh, Christianity was the revealed truth, and it reconciled humans to the uncontrollable winds of fortune with clear rules for this life and a promise of one to come. Through satirical portrayals of fortune-telling and hare-brained Amazonian adventures, Waugh argues that, lacking a basis of objective truth in their lives, people will regress to ever more ludicrous

behaviors in doomed attempts to control their fate.



CIVILIZATION VS. BARBARISM

The last third of *A Handful of Dust* features a shocking twist, pivoting from London society to the furthest reaches of the known world in the

Brazilian jungle. This unexpected move allows Waugh to sharpen his incisive critique of the “civilization” of his day. Waugh counterpoints Tony’s struggles in the Amazon with scenes of Brenda in London to highlight the barbarism of “civilized” life. Brenda stays in bed living off delivered sandwiches, while John Beaver abandons her now that her money and social clout have dissipated—the brute survival behavior of animals. Jock tells Brenda, who wonders about Tony’s safety in the jungle, that “[t]he whole world is civilized now, isn’t it—charabancs and Cook’s offices everywhere.” Waugh implicitly contrasts this superficial view of civilization-as-convenience with the deeper complex of morals and values that the term once embodied, and which his modern Londoners have so forsaken. Jock is of course wrong about the jungle: for Tony, the metaphorical vipers in the grass have become literal. In essence, however, the two places are the same.

Tony’s disappointment both in England and places abroad are guaranteed by the incoherence of his ideals. Modern English society has failed to conform to the Arthurian fantasy life he imagined at **Hetton**, so he turns his back on it to go questing after a mythical Amazonian city. Yet in his visions, this City is “Gothic in character, [...] a transfigured Hetton, pennons and banners floating on the sweet breeze.” Tony remains bound to his specific fantasy of civilization, yet this was essentially false to begin with: Hetton is not a medieval artifact but a tasteless neo-Gothic pastiche—and Tony is no chivalrous knight. He knows nothing of the values of faith and sacrifice embodied in the chivalric code, clinging rather to the coziness of their cheap imitation. When Brenda’s betrayal makes him recognize the disjunction between his Hetton fantasy’s civilized veneer and modern English reality, he strikes out in search of the real article. In doing so, he loses even the veneer. In other words, the novel’s juxtaposition of so-called “civilization” with its supposed opposite suggests that, in the modern world, civilization has become indistinguishable from barbarism.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



HETTON

The neo-Gothic country estate **Hetton**, Tony Last’s ancestral home, symbolizes empty nostalgia, and it acts as a kind of analogy for Tony himself. Though the estate in

fact dates back hundreds of years, Tony’s grandfather had it remodeled in the 1860s in a garish pastiche of medieval Gothic architecture—a popular trend at the time. By the 1930s, Hetton has gone wildly out of style, and it inspires disgust and contempt in the hip London crowd who favor slick modernism. Tony, however, is confident that all tastes are ephemeral and that Hetton will come back into fashion, and this belief supports his unflagging devotion to the house where he grew up. Tony’s attachment to Hetton points to a symbolic kinship between him and the house: they share a veneer of civility that’s well-intended but is simply inauthentic by nature. Just as the 19th century witnessed a fad for medieval aesthetics but without a revival of the chivalric social order and religious values that they originally embodied, Tony enjoys the superficial trappings of civilization—essentially class etiquette—without the hard-won faith and social obligation it once implied. Hetton’s redecoration was a sham, and it has already gone out of favor. Tony’s commitment to it puts him at odds with modernity, and this puts Tony in the unfortunate position of nostalgically defending what was a fake to begin with, while being too naïve to recognize it as such. Like the house, Tony’s own silly and antiquated habits provoke derision from cutting-edge London socialites. The estate’s claim on his imagination stays strong even when he tries momentarily to flee it in the Amazon, where he imagines the lost Amazonian city he seeks as “Gothic in character, all vanes and pinnacles, [...] a transfigured Hetton, pennons and banners floating on the sweet breeze.” His failure to see through this aesthetic reflects his lack of self-reflection generally.



TELEPHONES

Telephones represent the chaotic state of communication in modern life. Telephones are

everywhere in the first two-thirds of *A Handful of Dust*, frequently initiating major turns in the plot. The frenetic hive of gossip that modern London has become depends on the telephone for its existence. Waugh was especially sensitive to the social effects of the telephone since it was still a recent technology, the use of which was rapidly spreading. In Waugh’s view, telephones’ ability to simulate closeness and expedite communication actually imposes a kind of distance and alienation between people, which obstructs true, meaningful communication. The communicative rupture between Tony Last and his wife Brenda Last becomes undeniable when he travels all the way to London to visit her, but he can only reach her by telephone. The pressure of unprecedented technologies on modern life, symbolized in the telephone, makes communication and its contents shallow and cheap. Significantly, telephones completely disappear from the last third of the novel, when Tony travels to the Amazon rainforest. The metaphorical breakdown of communication represented in the telephone becomes dramatically literal for Tony in the end,

trapped and blocked from any contact with the outside world.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Back Bay Books edition of *A Handful of Dust* published in 2012.

Chapter 2: English Gothic—I Quotes

☞ When service was over he stood for a few minutes at the porch chatting affably with the vicar's sister and the people from the village. Then he returned home by a path across the fields which led to a side door in the walled garden; he visited the hothouses and picked himself a buttonhole, stopped by the gardeners' cottages for a few words (the smell of Sunday dinners rising warm and overpowering from the little doorways) and then, rather solemnly, drank a glass of sherry in the library. That was the simple, mildly ceremonious order of his Sunday morning, which had evolved, more or less spontaneously, from the more severe practices of his parents; he adhered to it with great satisfaction. Brenda teased him whenever she caught him posing as an upright, God-fearing gentleman of the old school and Tony saw the joke, but this did not at all diminish the pleasure he derived from his weekly routine, or his annoyance when the presence of guests suspended it.

Related Characters: Tony Last, Brenda Last

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 33

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes shortly after readers' introduction to Tony Last and his life at Hetton. Tony is a member of the landed gentry and prefers to spend his time on his ancestral country estate, while his wife Brenda has more interest in maintaining a social life in London but generally concedes to Tony's preferences. The surprise visit to Hetton of John Beaver, a disliked social climber and merely passing acquaintance, threatens to upend Tony's reliable Sunday routine described here. The routine is somewhat dull and sentimental—"mildly ceremonious"—and it quickly establishes Tony as an inoffensive but boring creature of habit. He takes "great satisfaction" from the ritual, suggesting almost a smugness in his performing the time-honored routine "rather solemnly," as if in imagined opposition to the barbarous modern habits and pace of life that he dislikes.

Yet the passage also gets to the crux of Tony's weakness of

character: the self-satisfied traditionalism of his Sunday routine does not grow out of a deep inner moral and religious code, and his preference for old-fashioned habits over modern ones is merely aesthetic and curmudgeonly. He makes no distinction between the Church service that begins his Sunday and the chatting, flower-picking, and glass of sherry that follow it, showing religion's superficiality for him. If he were attached to Christianity's teachings rather than its bland social ritual, he would presumably try to be hospitable rather than annoyed when a guest interrupted it.

☞ [Rev. Tendril's] sermons had been composed in his more active days for delivery at the garrison chapel; he had done nothing to adapt them to the changed conditions of his ministry and they mostly concluded with some reference to homes and dear ones far away. The villagers did not find this in any way surprising. Few of the things said in church seemed to have any particular reference to themselves. They enjoyed their vicar's sermons very much and they knew that when he began about their distant homes, it was time to be dusting their knees and feeling for their umbrellas.

Related Characters: Mr. Tendril

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 35-36

Explanation and Analysis

Tony has been firm in his resistance to spending any more time with John Beaver than he absolutely must, and he has once again pawned him off on Brenda so that he can go about his usual churchgoing Sunday routine. The Rev. Tendril preposterously continues to deliver the same sermons that he wrote while stationed in India decades ago, without alteration. Tendril's laziness humorously satirizes the church's failure to "adapt" its methods and teachings "to the changed conditions" under which modern parishioners live. Industrialism, WWI, and economic depression have caused massive upheavals in daily life, but the church keeps living in the past and preaching the same tired message.

In this light, Tendril and the church are responsible for the decline of religion's personal, spiritual relevance in the villagers' lives: "Few of the things said in church seemed to have any particular reference to themselves." By this point, however, the villagers don't "find this in any way surprising" and even "enjoyed the vicar's sermons very much." They have happily taken the lead given them by the church's inadequacy and let religiosity wilt, while upholding its

superficial rituals. On this last point, however, they stand in contrast to the openly irreligious London socialites, who are presented as totally debased.

☞ When Tony came back they were sitting in the library. Beaver was telling Brenda's fortune with cards. "... Now cut to me again," he was saying, "and I'll see if it's any clearer... Oh yes... there is going to be a sudden death which will cause you great pleasure and profit. In fact you are going to kill someone. I can't tell if it's a man or a woman... yes, a woman... then you are going to go on a long journey across the sea, marry six dark men and have eleven children, grow a beard and die."

"Beast. And all this time I've been thinking it was serious."

Related Characters: Brenda Last , John Beaver (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 38-39

Explanation and Analysis

Tony has successfully avoided John Beaver for the duration of his Sunday routine, but he unfortunately finds him with Brenda as soon as he returns to the house. While Tony strenuously dodges it, Brenda has actually been enjoying Beaver's company, and Beaver has been entertaining her by pretending to read her fortune. Returning to this passage after having finished the novel provides a glimpse of Waugh's literary method, wherein crucial events are explicitly anticipated in ways unknowable to both the characters and the reader the first time through. Beaver's fortune predicts John Andrew's "sudden death," which causes Brenda the pleasure and profit of freeing her from her marriage. The rest of the fortune—about an exotic overseas voyage, growing a beard, and dying—actually happens to Tony.

Of course, Beaver has no way of knowing his joke fortune will prove surprisingly true. His accuracy is a random act of chance. At the same time, however, it points to a kind of predetermination beyond human comprehension. Waugh intentionally constructed his novel this way, exploiting his authorial control to create an analogy for his religious argument. Just as his characters blunder through a world whose artistic design is hidden to them, humans live in world of apparent randomness that actually operates according to God's deeper but concealed purposes.

☞ "But don't you like the house?"

"Me? I detest it... at least I don't mean that really, but I do wish sometimes that it wasn't all, every bit of it, so appallingly ugly. Only I'd die rather than say that to Tony. We could never live anywhere else, of course."

Related Characters: Brenda Last , John Beaver (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 40-41

Explanation and Analysis

Tony has managed to get out of spending almost any time with John Beaver during his weekend stay at Hetton, but when the opportunity comes to give Beaver a tour of the house and grounds, Tony does so with gusto, enthusiastically showing him around for over two hours. Once he has left again, Brenda and Beaver are left alone together, and Brenda reveals her real feelings about Hetton to him. In itself, the fact that Brenda spills her closely guarded opinions about her own home to a man she has really just met indicates the degree of repression she must ordinarily feel around Tony. Tony's adoration of Hetton seems at least equal to his feelings for Brenda and John Andrew, their son. Because the house has gone so out of style, Tony's love for it has taken on a defensive, hypersensitive character, and Brenda clearly does not feel that she can speak her mind to him about it. Her concealment of her opinions nevertheless shows a respect for Tony's feelings that is worlds away from what her behavior towards him will become. There is ironic truth in her remark that "We could never live anywhere else": *they* indeed can and will not live anywhere else together; Brenda leaving Hetton ends their marriage.

☞ “What's all the news?”

“Ben's put the rail up ever so high and Thunderclap and I jumped it six times yesterday and six times again to-day and two more of the fish in the little pond are dead, floating upside down all swollen and nanny burnt her finger on the kettle yesterday and daddy and I saw a fox just as near as anything and he sat quite still and then went away into the wood and I began drawing a picture of a battle only I couldn't finish it because the paints weren't right and the grey carthorse the one that had worms is quite well again”

“Nothing much has happened,” said Tony. “We've missed you. What did you find to do in London all this time?”

Related Characters: Tony Last, Brenda Last , John Andrew (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 63

Explanation and Analysis

After John Beaver escorts Brenda to Polly Cockpurse's party in London, the two of them begin an affair that keeps Brenda in town for a few days longer than expected. When Brenda arrives, long overdue, back at Hetton, Tony and John Andrew go to meet her at the train. John Andrew's gush of “news” that his mother has missed provides a heartwarming view into a child's world, where everything that happens is interesting and important. Tony, by contrast, summarizes the same period of time by saying, “Nothing much has happened.” His assessment reveals the dullness of his adult perception of things, as well as the unexpected boredom of his daily life, which has become apparent in only a few days of Brenda's absence.

What's more, Tony's response signals a divide growing between himself and John Andrew. Not only does he not take notice of or find worth mentioning the sources of excitement that fill up his son's days, but he is also eager to quiet John Andrew down so that he can get information out of Brenda about her recent actions. Tony does not yet suspect her infidelity, but he is ill-equipped for even the few days' separation he has just endured, and he immediately feels discomfited. The passage indicates the growing toll that Brenda's affair will take on her and Tony's relationship with John Andrew, who becomes a victim of the increasingly limited attention they have to give him.

☞ But with the exception of her sister's, opinion was greatly in favour of Brenda's adventure. The morning telephone buzzed with news of her; even people with whom she had the barest acquaintance were delighted to relate that they had seen her and Beaver the evening before at a restaurant or cinema. It had been an autumn of very sparse and meagre romance; only the most obvious people had parted or come together, and Brenda was filling a want long felt by those whose simple, vicarious pleasure it was to discuss the subject in bed over the telephone [...] The choice of Beaver raised the whole escapade into a realm of poetry for Polly and Daisy and Angela and all the gang of gossips.

Related Characters: Brenda Last , John Beaver, Polly Cockpurse

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 67

Explanation and Analysis

While Tony broods at Hetton, Brenda and John Beaver's affair has entered full swing in London, quickly becoming the talk of the town. This passage captures the atmosphere of excitement in London around the unexpected development. The telephone figures centrally in their affair's rise to prominence in the local imagination. The device can spread news instantaneously while offering a sense of distance and privacy to the user; and this combination allows the town gossips to indulge their nosing and speculation without shame. The sense of unreality it affords absolves the gossips of normal human considerations, like the feelings of Tony or John Andrew, which never seem to be given a thought. The “vicarious pleasure” of speculating about someone else's affair finds a perfect home on the vicarious medium of the telephone. Waugh's choice of the word “buzzed” both evokes the excitement in the air and imbues it with a sense of insectoid menace, as if London's telephone wires were the fibers holding together a wasps' hive of gossip (perhaps with Polly Cockpurse as the queen wasp).

“How difficult it is for us,” he began, blandly surveying his congregation, who coughed into their mufflers and chafed their chilblains under their woolen gloves, “to realize that this is indeed Christmas. Instead of the glowing log fire and windows tight shuttered against the drifting snow, we have only the harsh glare of an alien sun; instead of the happy circle of loved faces, of home and family, we have the uncomprehending stares of the subjugated, though no doubt grateful, heathen. Instead of the placid ox and ass of Bethlehem,” said the vicar, slightly losing the thread of his comparisons, “we have for companions the ravening tiger and the exotic camel, the furtive jackal and the ponderous elephant...” And so on, through the pages of faded manuscript.

Related Characters: Mr. Tendril (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 71

Explanation and Analysis

The Christmas season has interrupted Brenda and John Beaver's regular London meetups, as Beaver travels to Ireland with his mother while Brenda returns to Hetton. On Christmas, the family goes to church, and Rev. Tendril delivers his usual Christmas sermon, providing an extended example of his technique of recycling sermons written decades ago for troops stationed in India. This passage offers one of the novel's most outrightly funny moments, reveling in the absurd incompatibility between Tendril's bombastic speech and the English countryside church where it is delivered.

At the same time, the sermon underlines the conflict between “civilization” and barbarism that structures the novel. The collapse of religious and cultural values amidst the upheavals of modernity have made England an unfriendly environment more akin to its far-flung colonial holdings: the “harsh glare of an alien sun” now metaphorically beats down even at home. As the novel proceeds, Tony certainly feels that he “[has] for companions the ravening tiger [and] the furtive jackal,” first metaphorically in the hostile circle of Brenda's friends, then literally in the harsh jungles of the Amazon. Ironically, by making a mockery of one of Christianity's holiest days, Rev. Tendril's absurd speech itself embodies the problem that it unintentionally describes.

Chapter 3: Hard Cheese on Tony Quotes

“You know there wasn't really much for her to do all the time at Hetton. Of course she'd rather die than admit it, but I believe she got a bit bored there sometimes. I've been thinking it over and that's the conclusion I came to. Brenda must have been bored...”

Related Characters: Tony Last (speaker), Brenda Last, Jock Grant-Menzies

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 77

Explanation and Analysis

In the months after Christmas, Brenda has been spending more and more of her time in London under the guise of an economics course, but really carrying on her affair with John Beaver. Tony goes to London to pay her a surprise visit, but when he arrives at her flat, she is “out somewhere” and can't be reached. He goes to Brat's social club, where he drinks heavily with Jock and begins spilling his maudlin ruminations. Tony's conclusion that Brenda had been bored at Hetton is spot on. The question is, did he actually just arrive at this insight after long consideration, or had he known of her boredom all along but been unwilling to acknowledge it?

The first scenario is perhaps more likely, and it underscores how his self-absorption barred him from ever asking or thinking much about Brenda's feelings at Hetton. In his mind, he was happy, so surely she was as well. The second scenario implies a slightly more malign Tony, who had suppressed his awareness of Brenda's boredom, or even intentionally created an atmosphere where she would be unwilling to vocalize it. In either case, his soppy, drunken confession of his insight is a pitiful scene.

“Nothing could have been more fortunate,” Brenda said. “If I know Tony, he'll be tortured with guilt for weeks to come.”

Related Characters: Brenda Last (speaker), Tony Last

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 89

Explanation and Analysis

After Brenda makes excuses not to see Tony on his surprise visit to London, Tony goes on a self-destructive drunken

spree with Jock. Brenda kicks Beaver out of her flat for fear of Tony coming by, but instead Tony just calls and bothers her repeatedly throughout the long night. Brenda's reaction the next day throws light on her moral character. Up to this point, she has been having a fun extramarital fling with practically zero consequences. Tony's actions last night, annoying as they may have been, clearly indicate for the first time that her absence and changed behavior are causing him acute psychological distress. Instead of taking stock of her own actions and considering the pain she is inflicting, she immediately seizes on the opportunity to employ guilt to continue cheating with impunity, knowing Tony will not think to pry again.

The issue of "knowing" Tony is crucial here. She does indeed correctly guess his reaction, suggesting a boring predictability in keeping with Tony's personality. Tony, by contrast, doesn't know Brenda nearly as well, seemingly failing to notice that she had been bored, and remaining incapable of believing that she would wrong him in all the ways she does throughout their separation. This imbalance in knowledge of the other partner, largely attributable to Tony's complacent lack of curiosity about his wife, gives Brenda the upper hand in their fragmenting marriage—all the way up until Tony's first truly unpredictable action, his rejection of her alimony demands.

☞ "But you can telephone her from here, can't you, daddy?
Why did you go all the way to London to telephone her?...
Why, daddy?"
"It would take too long to explain."

Related Characters: Tony Last, John Andrew (speaker), Brenda Last

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 90

Explanation and Analysis

Tony returns from his failed surprise visit to Brenda, hungover and horribly embarrassed, and still not having seen his wife. John Andrew has come to meet him at the Hetton train station, and he immediately floods Tony with a stream of enthusiastic questions about his visit to Brenda. Tony is in no mood to chat, and he curtly explains that he didn't see her; they only spoke over the telephone. John

Andrew's bafflement again highlights a distinction between a child's and an adult's perspective generally, and a growing rift between him and his father specifically. John Andrew's questions are unfiltered and totally justified: Tony going to London just to phone Brenda makes no sense, yet he lacks an adult's subtlety to dance around the clearly uncomfortable topic. The communicative barriers that stiffen between adults are unintelligible to the honest simplicity of a child's mind. Ironically, John Andrew's innocent questioning of this situation erects a communicative barrier between his father and himself: Tony lacks the patience to explain the complexities of adult relationships to his son. Hungover and annoyed by what he receives as pestering, he soon snaps at John Andrew, and a new coldness enters their relationship.

☞ "This *has* been a jolly weekend"

"I thought you were enjoying it"

"Just like the old times—before the economics began"

Related Characters: Tony Last, Brenda Last (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 115

Explanation and Analysis

Brenda has been increasingly absent from and openly scornful of Hetton, pushing Tony further into aggravation and uncertainty about their marriage. Since she plans to miss the upcoming Hetton fox hunt, a grand annual tradition, Brenda decides to appease Tony by devoting a whole weekend to him, and inviting up his actual friends rather than her new ones. Brenda's excuse for missing the fox hunt is an exam in her fictitious economics course—the course that has provided the cover for her whole affair with John Beaver. The cover is flimsy, and any amount of prying by Tony could easily unravel it, but he never tries. His refusal to pry is partly a lingering effect of the guilt Brenda exploits over his drunken spree in London, but it also signals both his weakness and his naïve complacency. Tony can sense that something is wrong in their marriage, but he lacks the courage to track it down. At the same time, he never seems to seriously suspect his cuckolding, as if he doesn't attribute to Brenda either the malice or the wherewithal to cheat on him. His low opinion of his wife's interests, responsible for the initial frustration that drove her to cheat on him, makes her alleged sudden interest in economics all the more

incomprehensible to him, and he takes a jab at it here. Of course, Tony is the one intellectually denuded here, as Brenda easily fools him into contentment with one weekend of playing nice.

☞ She hit him and the horse collected himself and bolted up the road into the village, but before he went one of his heels struck out and sent John into the ditch, where he lay bent double, perfectly still.

Everyone agreed that it was nobody's fault.

Related Characters: John Andrew , Miss Ripon

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 127

Explanation and Analysis

John Andrew has been allowed to participate in the grand annual fox hunt on Hetton grounds within certain limits, but the limits are reached with no foxes found, and Ben Hacket has to take him home. During a minor traffic jam, a noise startles Miss Ripon's unruly horse, and it fatally kicks him. Waugh's sentence underscores the randomness, even triviality, of the boy's death by putting it in an appended explanatory clause, as if it were just an afterthought to the horse bolting up the road. He never even uses the words "dead" or "died," giving the impression that John Andrew's death takes place in ellipsis. John Andrew's parents have increasingly ignored him in recent months, so his sudden deletion aptly concludes this trend.

The speed with which "everyone agreed" to the conclusion that the boy's death was "nobody's fault" bespeaks a sense of guilt in everyone present. However, the group nature of the experience rescues any one of them from receiving the blame. The uneasy agreement between them not to cast blame relies on their unspoken sense of common guilt, which itself provides a kind of paradoxical comfort in the face of the idea that it really was "nobody's fault," an act of pure randomness.

☞ "I only wanted to see [Rev. Tendril] about arrangements. He tried to be comforting. It was very painful... after all the last thing one wants to talk about at a time like this is religion."

Related Characters: Tony Last (speaker), Mrs. Rattery , Mr. Tendril

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 140

Explanation and Analysis

In the aftermath of John Andrew's death, Tony seems to be in a mild state of shock, but this allows him to handle all the necessary arrangements diplomatically without being overwhelmed with emotion. While Jock travels to London to deliver Brenda the news, Mrs. Rattery stays behind to keep Tony company. Though they have just met, Tony feels comfortable in her presence, candidly offering his real thoughts about visitors like Rev. Tendril and, by extension, religion. Tony, however, doesn't see his dismissal of religion in this moment as a personal revelation, but rather just the normal reaction. Waugh signals this with his generalizing stock phrase "after all," and the impersonal pronoun "one." This passage exposes the superficiality of religion in Tony's life, which serves as a much-beloved part of his Sunday routine but has nothing to offer him in a time of personal crisis. What's more, Tony makes no effort to pretend otherwise: the shallowness of his religiosity is freely admitted and assumed to be universal. Religion, at the end of the day, means no more to him than to the Londoners who openly avoid it, and his trifling attitude towards it is a sign of his generally weak and trivial existence.

☞ She frowned, not at once taking in what he was saying. "John... John Andrew... I... Oh thank God..." Then she burst into tears.

Related Characters: Brenda Last (speaker), John Beaver, Jock Grant-Menzies , John Andrew

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 143

Explanation and Analysis

After John Andrew's accidental death, Jock volunteers to deliver the news to Brenda in London so that Tony can rest and deal with business at Hetton. He finds her at Polly Cockpurse's fortune telling party and informs her that "John" has died in an accident. After a moment of confusion, she delivers these words, revealing that she had at first thought Jock meant John Beaver had died. In a damning moment of self-exposure, she blurts out "Oh thank God" to hear that in fact John Andrew is the victim. This brutal slip of the tongue reveals the true extent of her heartlessness,

valuing her boy toy over her own son, whom she sees as an impediment to her affair.

On the other hand, this passage captures a moment of naked honesty amid crisis, and it can even restore sympathy to Brenda and her actions thus far. This unguarded admission reveals just how in love with Beaver she is (foolish and misguided though that love may be), which doesn't justify but at least explains her appalling behavior up to this point. Furthermore, it sheds light on the extent to which she felt trapped with Tony and Hetton—a bondage for which John Andrew, through no fault of his own, served as an anchor. Though her reaction is shameful, it nevertheless conveys the vertiginous thrill of liberation.

☞ “But it's not true, is it?”

“Yes, I'm afraid it is. Everyone has known for some time.”

But it was several days before Tony fully realized what it meant. He had got into a habit of loving and trusting Brenda.

Related Characters: Tony Last, Jock Grant-Menzies (speaker), Brenda Last, John Beaver

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 152

Explanation and Analysis

Brenda returns to Hetton and helps finish the arrangements concerning John Andrew's death, but she then quickly leaves for a pre-appointed weekend at a friend's house. Her departure is shocking enough, but then she telegrams Tony from the friend's house saying that she is in love with John Beaver and will not return to Hetton. Jock, staying with Tony at the time, confirms the news. On one level, Tony's disbelief is understandable, as shock piles on shock. That the odious Beaver has stolen his wife, in the immediate wake of their son's death, is truly hard to believe. Yet Tony's cluelessness goes beyond his present shock; it stems from his profound naivety and his poor understanding of Brenda. He is literally the last person to find out: “Everyone has known for some time.”

Tony was in a position to be so brutally blindsided in this fashion because he has lived to an incredible degree according to “habit,” his stodgy and uncurious adherence to routine life in the home where he grew up, of which Brenda, for him, had been simply a docile part. Indeed, “loving and trusting Brenda” was not a profound gesture of personal devotion but a “habit” itself. This passive, presumptuous way of living exposes him to disaster when his assumptions are

upended.

Chapter 4: English Gothic—II Quotes

☞ “How's the old boy taking it?”

“Not so well. It makes me feel rather a beast,” said Brenda.

Related Characters: Brenda Last, Polly Cockpurse (speaker), Tony Last

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 153

Explanation and Analysis

In the wake of John Andrew's death, Brenda has suddenly separated from Tony and announced her love for John Beaver. Polly Cockpurse and her other friends ask her about the fallout, but they swear allegiance to Brenda no matter the outcome. The exchange encapsulates the breakdown of communication and moral confusion that saturates *A Handful of Dust*. Brenda has avoided talking to Tony, even over the phone, and her report that he's taking the news “[n]ot so well” is actually based on the accounts of intermediaries running between them. Moreover, the fact that it even needed to be asked how Tony was responding to Brenda's actions, and that Brenda is upset by his negative reaction—as if he could conceivably have any other—indicates how morally blind and dislocated Brenda and her friends are.

Brenda's remark that Tony's reaction “makes [her] feel rather a beast” is fishing for sympathy from her friends, although it does indicate some shred of conscience in her. The word choice, however, evokes the bestial undercurrent running under “civilized” society all through the novel—Rev. Tendril's tiger and furtive jackal. More specifically, it recalls Brenda's maiden name, Rex, which suggests both imperiousness and the surname of a ferocious dinosaur. In the novel's world, humans and beasts are hardly distinguishable.

☞ [Tony] reminded himself that phantasmagoric, and even gruesome as the situation might seem to him, he was nevertheless a host, so that he knocked at the communicating door and passed with a calm manner into his guest's room; for a month now he had lived in a world suddenly bereft of order; it was as though the whole reasonable and decent constitution of things, the sum of all he had experienced or learned to expect, were an inconspicuous, inconsiderable object mislaid somewhere on the dressing table; no outrageous circumstance in which he found himself, no new, mad thing brought to his notice, could add a jot to the all-encompassing chaos that shrieked about his ears.

Related Characters: Tony Last

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 167

Explanation and Analysis

Tony has agreed to the alimony terms Brenda has suggested through intermediaries, but due to the divorce laws of the time, both parties agree that Tony should frame himself for adultery to smooth the legal proceedings. He takes the prostitute Milly to a dingy seaside resort for a weekend of staged illicit lusts, to be documented by hired sleuths. This passage captures the clash between the nightmarish and utterly unexpected reality he now faces and the bone-deep sense of propriety to which he still clings. The “phantasmagoric, and even gruesome...situation” in which he now finds himself foreshadows the literal, gruesome phantasmagoria of his Amazonian fever dreams. Yet the fundamental rupture has already taken place: his sentimental trust in “the whole reasonable and decent constitution of things” has already been bankrupted, and this period between Brenda leaving him and his Amazon journey sees him futilely trying to maintain a sense of “order” amid the “all-encompassing chaos.” “Order” for Tony here consists in upholding the duty of a host. Ironically, his shirking this duty during John Beaver’s visit to Hetton indirectly allowed for Beaver and Brenda’s affair. He was disappointed in his own behavior at the time, and by now, it seems that he has learned his lesson.

☞ He hung up the receiver and went back to the smoking-room. His mind had suddenly become clearer on many points that had puzzled him. A whole Gothic world had come to grief... there was now no armour glittering through the forest glades, no embroidered feet on the green sward; the cream and dappled unicorns had fled...

Related Characters: Tony Last

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 184

Explanation and Analysis

After Tony follows through with the self-incriminating divorce evidence scheme, Brenda’s brother Reggie goes to meet him and reveals that Brenda’s reasonable alimony agreement was not genuine; she wants 2,000 pounds annually, enough to force Tony to sell Hetton. In disbelief, Tony calls Brenda, who confirms the demand, saying that it was John Beaver’s idea. This passage registers the sudden and massive disillusionment that Brenda’s words occasion in Tony.

Tony has indeed been “puzzled” on “many points” since Brenda left him; the act was so incongruous with what he thought he knew of both Brenda’s character and the way the world worked that he remains simply confused for a long while. This final trampling of any sentimental attachment to either conception takes down as well the “whole Gothic world” that comprised the fantasy in which he lived. The passage delights in the slight ridiculousness of that fantasy world’s décor, mock-sentimentally invoking the “cream and dappled unicorns” that melt in the light of the modern heartlessness and exploitation Brenda displays. Tony’s conception of the world, shaped by his garish neo-Gothic home, had always been silly. In truth, he should have recognized that long ago—before, for instance, agreeing to frame himself to aid his cheating wife in their divorce. The crumbling of his cherished fantasy-life, however, sets the stage for a radical act of self-assertion.

Chapter 5: In Search of a City Quotes

☞ “You’re the explorer, aren’t you?”

“Yes, come to think of it, I suppose I am.”

Related Characters: Tony Last (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 190

Explanation and Analysis

Shortly following Tony’s stunning announcement that he will concede nothing to Brenda because Winnie’s presence

in Brighton gives him an alibi, he finds himself on a mid-sized ocean liner headed across the Atlantic. Just a few weeks prior, he had been casting about for a vacation plan to get away from England, and he threw in his hat with the eccentric Dr. Messinger, joining his voyage seeking a legendary lost city in the Amazon. A passenger on deck asks him the question in this passage, which captures Tony's humorous passivity even in the midst of a life-altering commandeering of his own destiny. Tony's "come to think of it, I suppose I am" shows his continuing disinclination to assert himself, to think consciously about who he is and what he wants, even as he takes the first radical and unexpected turn in his life.

But the line also shows him warming up to the new identity: not having to work for a living, he has never previously been anything but "Tony Last." Now he not only has a title, but it's the boldest job description there is—one totally out of keeping with who he has been his whole, passive life. This change is exciting, but unfortunately, it doesn't mean much: Tony certainly goes along on Messinger's exploration, but he's mainly a dead weight who doesn't take too much interest in his surroundings or the projected destination. Tony thought that making the leap to join the expedition would suffice to transform him, but once in the thick of it, he acts basically the same.

For some days now Tony had been thoughtless about the events of the immediate past. His mind was occupied with the City, the Shining, the Many Watered, the Bright Feathered, the Aromatic Jam. He had a clear picture of it in his mind. It was Gothic in character, all vanes and pinnacles, gargoyles, battlements, groining and tracery, pavilions and terraces, a transfigured Hetton, pennons and banners floating on the sweet breeze, everything luminous and translucent; a coral citadel crowning a green hill-top sown with daisies, among groves and streams; a tapestry landscape filled with heraldic and fabulous animals and symmetrical, disproportionate blossom.

Related Characters: Tony Last

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 196

Explanation and Analysis

Tony, having deflected Brenda's extortion demands, has fled

England and its currently unpleasant associations and joined the zany explorer Dr. Messinger's quest for a lost Amazonian city. As he passes time aboard the long and boring transatlantic crossing, Tony rhapsodizes in his mind over the City they hope to find. This Gothic fantasy follows hard on the heels of his disenchanting realization that "a whole Gothic world had come to grief." The gushing descriptions of "vanes and pinnacles, gargoyles, battlements," and so on do indeed evoke "a transfigured Hetton," the genuinely medieval and enchanted city that the neo-Gothic Hetton strives to be.

Tony's hasty relapse into Gothic fantasia signals the sad limitations of his imagination. He has boldly, even recklessly, thrown himself into a loony voyage to the Amazon in order to flee England and Hetton, yet the utopia he conjures is just another version of home. The initial impetus behind his brash decision—namely, to shake off his passive lifestyle and redefine himself—seems already thwarted. The new fantasy, as it stands, seems destined for disappointment in the very un-Gothic Amazon jungle, about which Tony seems to know nothing at all.

“Is it *absolutely* safe?”

“Oh, I imagine so. The whole world is civilized now, isn't it—charabancs and Cook's offices everywhere.”

Related Characters: Brenda Last, Jock Grant-Menzies (speaker), Tony Last

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 211

Explanation and Analysis

As Tony and Dr. Messinger hack their way through the Amazonian jungle, Tony falls prey to a thousand minor ills, from constant insect attacks to sunburn and scabs. The narrative intermittently cuts back to England where, in this passage, Brenda dances with Jock at a social gathering. Waugh's cutting back and forth between the two locales serves two purposes: first, to humorously contrast the Amazonian sufferings to which Tony has pointlessly subjected himself with the refined niceties of home; and second, to undercut those very niceties with an image of what really lies beneath them—barbarism and savagery.

In this light, Jock's comment that "the whole world is civilized now" serves both purposes: in the sense he means it, it's hilariously untrue of Tony's hostile environment,

which is anything but safe. At the same time, the shallow sense in which he conceives of “civilization,” equating it with niceties like autobuses (charabancs), reveals how unmoored the supposedly civilized society in England has become. Purely technological and materialistic, it abounds with bestial human counterparts to the real beasts in Tony’s surroundings.

☞ “From now onwards the map is useless to us,” said Dr. Messenger with relish.

Related Characters: Dr. Messenger (speaker), Tony Last

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 217

Explanation and Analysis

With the English-speaking Rosa’s help, Dr. Messenger has successfully enlisted a group of Macushi Indians to guide him and Tony further into the jungle, intending to close in on the elusive lost City. The expedition has already hit several hiccups and gotten seemingly disoriented, but Dr. Messenger’s confidence remains unflagging. Tony goes along dutifully and scarcely raises a peep, so his thoughts about their prospects are hard to gauge. Dr. Messenger’s declaration in this passage encapsulates the general feeling of the latter portion of the novel, and it invokes the theme of aimlessness and the loss of tradition that has run through the whole work.

Tony has lived by the “map” of antiquated notions and habits his whole life. Brenda’s betrayal forces him to realize that that map doesn’t correspond with the real world and must be abandoned. The customs of the old world, like the faded sheets of Rev. Tendril’s ancient sermons, are “useless to us” “[f]rom now onwards.” But without the guideposts of tradition, Waugh suggests, people are adrift. The delirious freedom of living without a “map,” as the ruthlessly modern London socialites do, is really an existential abyss that metaphorically corresponds to the literal maplessness and terror of Tony’s jungle misadventure.

☞ For weeks past she had attempted to keep a fair mind towards Tony and his treatment of her; now at last she broke down and turning over buried her face in her pillow, in an agony of resentment and self-pity.

Related Characters: Brenda Last

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 246

Explanation and Analysis

While Tony continues to struggle through the Amazon, back in England, Brenda’s fortunes have turned: her cash has dried up, and John Beaver and her socialite friends have left her behind. She desperately petitions the Last family solicitor for alimony funds in Tony’s unexpectedly long absence, but he insists that Tony specifically instructed against this, and informs her that Richard Last and his family are Hetton’s heirs. This passage continues Waugh’s counterpointing of Brenda’s and Tony’s parallel demises: just like Tony in the Amazon, Brenda has become too weak to feed herself and collapses in “an agony of resentment and self-pity.” The parallelism underscores the barbarism in England that can consume even its most gleeful practitioners.

Yet Brenda’s change of fortune has brought her no insight: her resentment remains for Tony, and for herself she only has pity. She congratulates herself on her “[attempt] to keep a fair mind towards” the man whose life she upended and whom she tried to extort, yet she cannot maintain it in the face of his continuing to resist her plunder. The absurd self-absorption of this stance illustrates the impossibility of Brenda taking responsibility for her actions. Her current plight is pitiful but not pitiable.

Chapter 6: Du Côté de Chez Todd Quotes

☞ “I will tell you what I have learned in the forest, where time is different. There is no City. Mrs. Beaver has covered it with chromium plating and converted it into flats.”

Related Characters: Tony Last (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 255

Explanation and Analysis

After Dr. Messenger’s death, Tony is left alone in the jungle, totally delirious with fever and seemingly guaranteed to die. Astonishingly, he stumbles onto the ranch of the English-speaking local honcho Mr. Todd, who will nurse him back to health. When Tony arrives, he is still gripped by wild hallucinations combining all his experience of the last several months, and this passage provides his crazed

summation of the phantasmagoria. Unlike Brenda, whose lowest point brings her despair but no insight, Tony's delirium grants him a real vision of the nature of things. Tony is finally stripped of every fantasy he ever held to, as he comes to see that "[t]here is no City"—i.e., utopia, the gushing Gothic dream, a fundamental order and civilization: none of them are real.

But the realization is ambiguous: "There is no City" implies that all ideas of order are fictions, and that a heart of darkness lies at the center of things. But "Mrs. Beaver has covered it with chromium plating and converted it into flats" implies that the City once really existed, and that the rapacious, anti-traditional forces of modernity embodied in Mrs. Beaver have willfully destroyed it. When he returns to health, Tony loses the insight he gained in delirium, and the ambiguity is never settled; Waugh instead leaves it for the reader to ponder.

☞ "Do you believe in God?"

"I suppose so. I've never really thought about it much."

Related Characters: Tony Last, Mr. Todd (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 257

Explanation and Analysis

As Mr. Todd slowly brings Tony out of his feverish madness and back to health, he can increasingly converse with his guest, sharing much about his own background and also inquiring about Tony's beliefs. Mr. Todd's father was a missionary, hence his interest in the existence of God, but he doesn't press Tony on the point. Tony's admission that he has "never really thought about it much" encapsulates the weakness of his character. His disinclination to probe the religion he nominally subscribes to and clarify his own deepest beliefs is of a piece with his incuriosity about his surroundings, including his wife. Waugh suggests that this brand of socially commonplace impersonal agnosticism leads to a dulling of spirit that will make one blunder one's way through a vague and incomprehensible life. Tony's trifling attitude towards the most fundamental question reflects the general passive laziness of his existence. Ironically, Tony will have the rest of his life to ponder such questions as he languishes in the jungle confines of Mr. Todd's ranch. Mr. Todd, whose name means "death" in German, perhaps allegorically represents the prison of death from which Waugh believed Christianity provided the escape. Tony fails to seize on this escape and is left to his poetic doom.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1: DU CÔTÉ DE CHEZ BEAVER

In 1930s London, interior decorator Mrs. Beaver stands in front of an actively burning house and discusses with her son the profit to be made from redecorating it. Her son, John Beaver, is an unemployed 25-year-old Oxford graduate who lives at home with his mother, a widow. The two gossip together, and Mrs. Beaver encourages John's social climbing and freeloading efforts. John usually sits at home by the **telephone**, waiting for an invite to a free meal. These invitations are often last-minute, as his friends ask him to fill in for people who dropped out at the 11th hour.

John Beaver has received a passing and probably insincere invite from Tony Last to spend the weekend at Hetton, his country estate. Mrs. Beaver advises him to hold Tony to his promise, insisting that Beaver send the Lasts a telegram instead of calling them, since this will make it harder for them to come up with an excuse to go back on the invitation. She also explains that Tony's wife is Brenda, a once highly desired girl whom she feels is wasted on the boring Tony. Mrs. Beaver, for her part, always thought Brenda should have ended up with someone like Jock Grant-Menzies.

While waiting by the **phone** in the hopes of receiving a lunch invite, John Beaver is delighted to finally get a call. It's from Mrs. Tipping, who Beaver knows is having a luncheon party that day. Expecting to receive a last-minute invite, he eagerly answers—but Mrs. Tipping only asks if he knows how she could get in touch with Jock Grant-Menzies, to whom Beaver introduced her the previous night. Beaver suggests that she try reaching Jock at a gentleman's club called Brat's. Mrs. Tipping thanks him and quickly ends the call.

John Beaver heads to the pseudo-elegant social club Brat's, which was established just after World War I by young men who wanted a place to socialize without being judged by the older generations. Now, though, these men have themselves become middle-aged, and they look down on Beaver's generation, which is made up of young men who have never been to war and don't seem manly or gentlemanly. In particular, Beaver isn't very popular at the club, though the older men do accept people like Jock Grant-Menzies.

The opening scene displays Mrs. Beaver's ruthless profit-seeking instinct, seeing personal financial opportunity in the tragedies of others—foreshadowing the very last scene of the novel. Mrs. Beaver's son shares his mother's exclusive interest in self-advancement, but he lacks her shrewd determination and is more of a free-floating parasite. The name "Beaver" captures both the mother's industriousness and the son's absurdity.



John Beaver's practice here reveals what must be his standard operating procedure—squeezing an invite out of someone in passing and then unexpectedly following up on it. Mrs. Beaver's cynical advice, and her infinite supply of pertinent gossip, bolster her dim son's social climbing career. This scene also highlights the totality of her influence on John in the absence of his deceased father.



The ironic twist in this phone call illustrates Beaver's sad dependence on others—if he could find employment, he would not need to rely on others for food, and he would also probably earn more respect from the social circle on whom he constantly freeloads. His mother acts as a modest safety net, but Beaver's laziness renders him, in practice, a kind of bourgeois panhandler.



The social dynamics at Brat's club provide a glimpse of the confusion and frayed social fabric of England between the wars. The normal progression of generations has been interrupted by WWI, Europe's first major conflict in a century, which left the veterans' generation alienated from those both older and younger. The likeable Jock can bridge this divide, while Beaver cannot.



At Brat's, John Beaver sits off to the side instead of going up to the bar. Eventually, Jock Grant-Menzies comes over and buys him a drink. The two men talk about Mrs. Tipping, and Jock says he has no interest in going to her luncheon party—he doesn't like social engagements of that kind. Preparing for his trip to Brenda and Tony Last's country estate, Beaver asks Jock about the couple, and Jock tells him that Tony Last is an enviably happy man.

As John Beaver and Jock chat, a server comes over and informs Beaver that he has an unpaid tab from the previous month, but Beaver quickly dismisses him, acting as if paying it simply slipped his mind. Soon enough, Beaver stands to leave, flippantly assuming Jock probably doesn't want another drink—but Jock says he actually *does* want another round. Beaver quickly places the order, and when the server asks if he should put the round on his tab, Beaver says yes. Later, after Beaver has left, Jock tells some other club members that he made Beaver pay for a drink. When the other members note that Beaver must have hated this, Jock says, "He nearly died of it."

After leaving Jock, John Beaver goes downstairs and calls home to see if there are any messages. He learns that Mrs. Tipping called to invite him to her luncheon party. Beaver asks his mother's staff to send word that he's on his way and will be a little late.

Jock demonstrates why people like him in his easygoing display of warmth towards the unliked Beaver. His lack of interest in the luncheon that Beaver was desperate to join likewise indicates both a firmer social standing and a greater self-assurance than Beaver possesses. Jock's "enviably" comment is foreboding, considering Mrs. Beaver's remark about boring Tony and beautiful Brenda.



Beaver manages to get by while being perennially broke by taking advantage of gentlemanly customs like buying your mate a drink and charging things to a long-running tab. When confronted with his fiscal shortcomings, he awkwardly tries to play them off. Jock was benevolent in going over to join Beaver, but he couldn't resist making him squirm by obliging Beaver to buy him a drink in return, and sharing a laugh about it afterward with the other club members.



Beaver here displays his parasitic nature, as he all too eagerly leaps on the spot at the luncheon that Jock, who sees this kind of gathering as beneath his interest, declined.



CHAPTER 2: ENGLISH GOTHIC—I

As the day begins, Tony Last lays in bed at Hetton, reflecting on the estate: the neo-Gothic style of its 1860s renovation has become ridiculous to modern tastes, but Tony is confident that it will come back in style. He knows that maintaining such a sprawling, archaic house is expensive and inconvenient, but his sentimental attachment to the estate runs deep. He grew up here and still sleeps in his childhood bedroom—named, like all the rooms in the house, after figures from Arthurian legend (his is Morgan le Fay). These days, the pseudo-medieval décor throughout the house is in a state of mild disrepair, but Tony doubts whether he could find craftsmen today with the skill and subtlety that the repairs would demand.

Tony's unhurried morning routine, waking up in his childhood bedroom in a house fashioned after medieval romantic legend, illustrates the coddled and somewhat childish and naïve life he has been privileged to lead, as a member of the landed gentry. Nevertheless, his concern for the repairs shows a mature appropriation of his childhood surroundings, and his commitment to the estate's unfashionable aesthetic shows his willingness to stand against the current of popular taste. The irony is that the house is not ancient at all.



Tony rouses himself, heads down to Brenda Last's room, and joins her in her bed, an uncharacteristically modern piece of furniture that she had insisted upon having. The two canoodle while she goes through the morning mail, reporting various social invites, and then reads aloud from the newspaper. Brenda reads the sensational news of violent crimes in the same casual tone as the local puff pieces, among which are featured her brother Reggie, an explorer, and Jock Grant-Menzies, who's a member of Parliament.

Brenda then reads from a serialized story in the paper and surprises Tony with a pop quiz, exposing him for not paying attention. Tony similarly shows no interest in the social invites they've received and dismisses them all out of hand. He dislikes company, whether in the form of leaving Hetton or of hosting guests. Brenda complains that having a huge house with such expensive upkeep is "pointless" without having guests, offending Tony. Their spat, however, is only mild and playful.

Outside, Tony and Brenda's young son John Andrew practices riding on his horse Thunderclap—a gift from his uncle Reggie—with Ben, the gruff stable tender. Ben entertains John Andrew with uncouth stories about livestock, including a mule named Peppermint, who drank a whole WWI troop's rum supply in the trenches and died. Ben has also taught John Andrew to swear, horrifying the boy's prim nanny: he calls her a "silly old tart," and she reports his language to his parents, blaming Ben for the crass behavior John Andrew has started to exhibit.

Tony and Brenda are privately amused by John Andrew's insult to the nanny, but Tony feels he must reprimand him anyhow. He explains to John Andrew that Ben is of a lower class and his behavior must not be emulated. John Andrew, however, claims to love Ben more than his own mother. Tony gets serious and tells John Andrew that Hetton will one day belong to him, and that he must learn to act the part of a gentleman and "be considerate to people less fortunate than you, particularly women." As punishment for John Andrew's swearing, Tony tries to take away a day's riding, but he easily folds under his son's complaints. John Andrew, meanwhile, continues to casually swear.

Tony and Brenda dine alone in their palatial dining hall, which varies wildly in temperature despite their several attempts to stabilize it. Though both healthy, they adhere to a fad diet barring starch and proteins from the same meal, as a way to add structure and interest to their meals.

Tony and Brenda seem to enjoy a mutual marital bliss, although Brenda's modern bed—and the fact that they sleep in different rooms—points to some differences between them. Brenda's uniformly casual tone in reading disturbing news articles suggests some callousness in her personality.



Tony not paying attention to his wife, and Brenda's evident dissatisfaction with his aversion to social gatherings, here take the form of a lighthearted tiff—but they foreshadow a deeper rift. Tony's infatuation with Hetton seems to crowd out most of the other aspects of social life in which Brenda retains an interest.



Ben Hacket cuts a notably more vigorous and earthy character than anyone seen so far, an indicator of his lower social and economic class. John Andrew is too young to have internalized the rules and proprieties of British class etiquette, and he shows a natural male enthusiasm for Ben's vulgar tales and tough comportment. The nanny is a traditional worrywart and defender of propriety.



Tony and Brenda can privately appreciate John Andrew's innocence and share a laugh at the humorless nanny. However, the incident provides occasion for Tony to indoctrinate John Andrew in class ideology and etiquette. Once learned, that code of etiquette can be privately laughed at, but it must be publicly adhered to as a matter of appearance. The flimsiness of that superficial system is evident in Tony's easy surrender to John Andrew's complaints. The moment is ambiguous, showing both Tony's affection for his son and his general weakness.



The solitary meal in the giant, poorly heated hall emphasizes Tony and Brenda's social isolation at Hetton, and the impracticality of its upkeep. Their embrace of a fad diet seems to point to an absence of meaningful structure in their lives.



Suddenly, a telegram arrives from John Beaver, announcing his imminent arrival by train. Tony is aghast that Beaver has actually accepted his insincere invitation, and he begins plotting how to make his stay uncomfortable enough that he'll swiftly leave. Brenda does not know Beaver but supports Tony's plan, recalling with displeasure that they owe his mother Mrs. Beaver some money. She volunteers to entertain Beaver while Tony flees to his chores.

Brenda feels less self-conscious without Tony around and actually enjoys chatting with John Beaver as they stroll around the grounds. Beaver updates Brenda on the London gossip and social happenings from which she has been largely absent. When Beaver mentions Polly Cockpurse's upcoming party, Brenda says that she and Tony were invited but don't expect to go, since "[w]e never go anywhere nowadays."

John Andrew arrives and begins rattling off crude questions to the new guest, forcing John Beaver to admit that he is poor and unemployed—though he remains cool while doing so. That evening, Tony joins Beaver and Brenda for dinner, and then they all go to a movie that Beaver has seen before but pretends like he hasn't. Tony assigns Beaver to a terrible room for the night but then feels guilty about it. Beaver passes a sleepless night in his uncomfortable bed. Brenda, meanwhile, seems to like Beaver fine.

The next day, Tony once again leaves Brenda with John Beaver—who has decided to return home early, as Tony hoped. Tony goes to the estate church, as is his custom, enjoying chat with the villagers. On the way, John Andrew recounts Ben's vulgar story of Peppermint the mule, killed by his rum consumption. Tony finds this story sad, but John Andrew says that he had thought so too until Ben explained that it's actually hilarious.

At church, the Rev. Tendril, as always, delivers one of his sermons written decades ago for troops stationed in India, without changing a word. The villagers in the congregation are well accustomed to these bizarrely incongruous sermons and don't find anything wrong with them, as they expect nothing of personal relevance from the pleasant ritual of churchgoing. Afterward, Tony feeds the villagers "the invariable formula" of mild sickness as an excuse for why Brenda couldn't come. John Andrew continues telling the story of Peppermint to anyone who will listen, earning a further rebuke from his nanny. On the way home, Tony fulfils another custom by picking buttonhole flowers from the estate gardens.

Tony embraces the trappings of chivalry and nobility at Hetton, but he freaks out when hospitality is asked of him—based on an invite that he actually made, however insincere—and he tries to subvert it at once. Brenda steps up to deal with the unwelcome guest, hinting at both Tony's weakness and her own hunger for human contact.



Beaver's arrival makes Brenda realize just how isolated she has been, giving her a taste of the swinging London life that she left behind for Tony. The fact that she quickly takes to the unliked Beaver perhaps indicates the low bar she has set at this point for social contact of any kind.



Beaver displays a surprising grace under pressure, owning up to his own petty existence. His good form persists as he stoically endures a movie that he's already seen in order to avoid awkwardness. Tony, by contrast, continues his ungracious hosting by putting Beaver in an inhospitable room, although he knows it's wrong. Brenda may well register the unexpected imbalance in conduct between the two men.



Tony's methodical inhospitality has worked, but even the few hours that remain of Beaver's truncated visit are too much for him to tolerate, so Brenda graciously steps up again. John Andrew, meanwhile, continues to display the rough influence of Ben, whose conception of humor embraces the dark and the obscene that Tony's sentimentality shuns.



Almost as surprising as Tendril's absurdly unsuitable sermons is the parishioners' placid reception of them. Clearly, neither party is concerned with this ritual making substantive sense. Tony matches the "invariable formula" of Tendril's sermons with a formula of his own about Brenda's perennial absence, showing the blithe superficiality of the whole custom. Meanwhile, John Andrew's crass behavior continues to upset the behavioral class distinctions between Tony and the poorer village parishioners.



While Tony is gone, John Beaver and Brenda continue to get along, and Brenda again laments her isolation at Hetton, where she and Tony “never make any new friends.” When Tony returns, Beaver is reading Brenda’s palm, seriously at first but soon revealing his reading as a farce. Alone with Tony, Brenda again denies that Beaver is all that bad and claims he even resembles her and Tony, which Tony flatly rejects.

Tony and Brenda give John Beaver a two-hour tour of Hetton, with Tony proudly pointing out every feature and ancestral knickknack in the estate. Beaver is a well-practiced house guest and politely shows interest throughout the tour. Once Tony departs again, Brenda reveals her real loathing for the unstylish estate, which she hides from Tony. She notes that if they sold it they could be quite rich, whereas now maintaining the house and staff eats up all their wealth. Yet she’s aware that Tony would never agree to part with the house—unlike her own family, whose ancestral estate her brother Reggie sold without objection.

Brenda convinces Beaver to stay another night, to Tony’s chagrin. She and Beaver play parlor games while Tony reads the papers. Tony is relieved when Beaver finally leaves, but Brenda doesn’t seem to share his contempt for their guest. When Beaver returns home, he tells Mrs. Beaver that Brenda mentioned interest in finding a London apartment, unbeknownst to Tony. Mrs. Beaver is excited about the potential business.

Brenda goes to visit her sister Marjorie in London, as she does on occasion, always travelling by third class rail. Surprised to hear that John Beaver had been a guest at Hetton, Marjorie has nothing kind to say about him. Nevertheless, she presses Brenda until she admits her infatuation with Beaver, despite finding him “pathetic.” She reiterates that she rarely sees young men in her social life these days.

At lunch, they run into the socialite Polly Cockpurse, who again invites them to her upcoming party. Also present is Mrs. Beaver, who aggressively markets a London flat to Brenda, inviting her over for a cocktail that evening to further discuss the lease. Brenda wonders doubtfully whether John Beaver will be home when she visits, but indeed he is, despite two other dinner invitations. Mrs. Beaver delivers a sales pitch for her sleek, minimalist apartment offerings. Later, John Beaver walks Brenda to the train, but denies her request that he take her to Polly’s party—secretly because he doesn’t want to take on the likely expenses involved in dinner and cab fare.

Beaver continues to perform surprisingly well as a guest; the success of his lame palm-reading gag again suggests that Brenda is starved for casual social interaction of any kind. As Brenda continues to warm to Beaver, Tony insists on the absolute difference and incompatibility between Beaver and himself.



Tony’s pride in Hetton overrules even his antipathy to spending time with Beaver, and he gladly inflicts an incredibly detailed house tour on his guest. Finally, in Beaver, Brenda has found someone to whom she can voice her true contempt for the garish mansion, which was implicit in her choice of a modern bed. Her preference for the hard cash from selling it aligns her with the shortsighted fashion-chasers whom Tony imagines he is resisting in defending Hetton.



The pattern of the weekend continues, as Brenda acts as a gracious host to Beaver and finds that he is not such bad company after all, while Tony had his mind made up long before Beaver’s arrival and continues not to engage. Brenda’s mention of interest in a London apartment hints at an incipient fraying in her and Tony’s marriage.



Brenda’s habitual travel by third-class rail reinforces her complaint about being cash-poor due to the expenses of upkeep at Hetton. Marjorie aligns with the general negative view of Beaver, and her shock at Brenda’s crush on him indicates the wild improbability of their romantic pairing.



Brenda’s lunch out with Marjorie gives her a taste of the London high life she left behind. It also, between the glad-handing Polly Cockpurse and the relentless operator Mrs. Beaver, seems to validate Tony’s aversion to participating in the scene. Brenda’s asking Beaver to take her to the party is a conscious lowering of herself, and Beaver’s reluctance to accept her request indicates how thoroughly cheap and lazy he is.



Brenda returns to Hetton totally drained from travel and uninterested in conversation with Tony. The next day, she receives a telegram from John Beaver saying that he can take her to Polly Cockpurse's party after all. Leaving Tony and John Andrew back at Hetton, Brenda meets Beaver in London for dinner before the party. After a drink at Marjorie's, in the cab to the restaurant, Beaver tries to kiss Brenda. She resists, leaving Beaver confused. He makes an awkward apology over dinner, but Brenda implies that her issue was with Beaver's clumsiness rather than the attempt itself. Brenda pays for the meal, and in the subsequent cab to the party she takes the lead and kisses Beaver.

The party is a predictable London soiree, successfully boosting Polly Cockpurse's social clout as she had desired. Throughout the evening, Brenda misreads John Beaver's social climbing priorities, and he has a frustrating evening of repeatedly ending up alone. Brenda frets over him not enjoying himself, but she still dances with Jock Grant-Menzies and other old friends—none of whom like Beaver, but with whom Beaver is eager to be seen. Beaver is cold to Brenda when they split for the night, and he remains so when she **telephones** him romantically once they're home.

The next morning, Brenda is self-conscious about this apparent rejection and affirms to Marjorie her illogical attraction to the admittedly unlikable John Beaver. Polly calls up and reveals that Brenda's dalliance with Beaver is already the talk of the town. At their home, Mrs. Beaver exhorts her son to pursue Brenda for the sake of his own social climbing and to secure her rental of one of Mrs. Beaver's apartments. Beaver resists, again invoking the continual costs of entertaining a woman. Brenda has given up on Beaver calling her as he'd promised and heads to lunch with Marjorie. By coincidence, Beaver is there, and makes a lame excuse for not calling. Brenda lets it slide and invites him to a movie, before brusquely telegraphing Tony that she's staying in London a few more days.

Brenda returns to Hetton, an excited John Andrew, and a seemingly irked Tony. John Andrew gushes about all the goings-on she has missed, including his horse-jumping progress and a drawing he's working on, but Tony's report is that "[n]othing much has happened." Brenda immediately mentions the desired London flat to Tony and begins wearing away at his predictable refusals, laying on the charm while conjuring all kinds of validations and flimsy arguments. Tony begins to cave in to her, but he mentions that the expense of the flat would mean having to delay overdue repairs at Hetton.

Beaver's change of heart perhaps suggests the Machiavellian influence of Mrs. Beaver. Brenda makes a brief point of resisting Beaver's clumsy seduction, but she doesn't maintain the act for long and clearly desires him. The speed with which she seems to have fallen for the unremarkable Beaver, to the neglect of her husband and young son, reveals just how bored and desperate she has become at Hetton. Beaver's initial and purely selfish reluctance to escort Brenda to the party seems to have psychologically flipped the script on her, despite her obvious social superiority.



Brenda effortlessly reenters the glamorous scene in which she was once a star, while Beaver remains a frustrated outsider looking in. Yet Brenda herself seems oblivious to this palpable imbalance in their social standing. Beaver's unjustified rudeness to Brenda should be enough for her to dismiss him entirely, but his lack of interest seems only to capture her heart even more.



Brenda is sharp enough to recognize Beaver's evident faults, and even his apparent lack of any positive qualities, but this only confirms the irrational, uncontrollable nature of infatuation. Beaver's pathetic resistance to Brenda's advances out of simple stinginess adds another level of absurdity to her fixation on him. He needs his opportunistic mother's goading to relent, and once he does, Brenda throws herself at him without reservation. The ubiquitous and instantaneous spread of gossip in London stands in contrast to Tony's ignorance as he putters around Hetton.



Tony has felt the sting of Brenda's impromptu sojourn in London. His aggravation has apparently blinded him to the exciting world of young John Andrew's adventures, as he has nothing to report to Brenda. Brenda's brashness in requesting Tony to pay for a London apartment that will undoubtedly go to accommodating her new affair indicates how rapidly she has lost interest in, and respect for, Tony. The fact that the slick, efficient flat comes at the expense of Hetton repairs emphasizes the conflict between Tony's stubborn tastes and Brenda's embrace of modernity.



Brenda swiftly returns to London and views one of Mrs. Beaver's flats with the confidence of a definite customer. In the meantime, however, Brenda continues to stay with Marjorie, who maintains her condemnation of Brenda's affair, calling it "hard cheese on Tony." The rest of the London gossips, however, seem enthralled with the development, eagerly reporting on sightings of Brenda and John Beaver together out on the town. Brenda had always captivated the minds of those who live off gossip and fantasizing about others' lives: her beauty and elegance had once made her highly coveted around London, but then, like a fairytale princess, she became shut up in the remote environs of Hetton with her dull husband.

The sheer unlikelihood of the widely disliked John Beaver being the one to steal Brenda's heart has made her story even more fantastical and poetic. Mrs. Beaver is as thrilled as everyone else, seeing the affair as a wonderful improvement for her rather directionless son. John Beaver, for his part, is suddenly a "person of interest" for the first time in his life, winning esteem from the crowd at Brat's. One night at her new apartment, Brenda enthuses about the flat to Tony over the **telephone** while Beaver lies beside her in bed.

At Christmas, John Beaver and Mrs. Beaver go to Ireland, while Tony's extended family comes to Hetton. Though comparatively poor, Tony's relatives consider themselves at home in the family estate and make Brenda uncomfortable with their endless and un-classy parlor games in which she is forced to participate. Hetton winding up in Tony's hands rather than these relatives' was due only to the custom of inheritance by the firstborn son.

From Ireland, John Beaver sends Brenda a thoughtless, unfinished thank-you note for an expensive ring she gave him. Brenda interprets the inconsiderate note as a lack of interest from Beaver and resigns herself to the fact. Over New Years, Tony uncharacteristically insists on accompanying Brenda to a friend's home, because he's seen so little of her lately. Once there, he is surprised to find that Beaver is among the other guests. She and Beaver studiously avoid each other all weekend. The New Year begins with Brenda telling Tony she's resolved to take up a course in economics in London, as Hetton and John Andrew get along fine without her.

Brenda's confidence when viewing Mrs. Beaver's apartment again indicates the rapidity with which she has elected to leave Hetton behind and embrace a swinging London lifestyle. As Brenda's sister, Marjorie lacks the interest in gossiping about her that has captivated the rest of the scene, and she might likewise be in the best position to change Brenda's mind. Yet her reprimands fall on deaf ears, as Brenda's infatuation with Beaver is already too deep.



The glee with which everyone in the London scene—even the philanderer's mother—accepts and encourages this improbable affair reveals the casual heartlessness of this slice of society. No one aside from Marjorie seems to give much thought to Tony's feelings if he were ever to find out. Brenda's disrespect for him advances even to the point of taking his calls with her lover in bed with her.



The holidays and Beaver's departure force Brenda to spend more time at Hetton than she has lately been doing. The annual gathering of Tony's cousins provides a window onto the oddities of the British class system, where wealth passes only to the firstborn and the other branches of the family sink into a lower class, with accordingly different behaviors.



Through mere thoughtlessness and lethargy, Beaver continues to wage inadvertent psychological warfare on the abject Brenda, who wraps herself ever more tightly around his finger. His inconsiderate behavior and failure to give adequate thanks for Brenda's lavish gift only fuel Brenda's infatuation with him. Tony's presence creates awkwardness, but he remains happily oblivious to any foul play. Brenda conjures up a fictitious plan to study economics as a way to spend more time with Beaver in London, signaling her increasing loss of interest in her husband and son.



CHAPTER 3: HARD CHEESE ON TONY

At Brat's, Tony and Jock Grant-Menzies have both been ditched by their dates and link up to drink heavily. Tony had made a surprise visit to Brenda in London, but she is "out somewhere." Jock is immediately uncomfortable as he tries to gauge how much, if anything, Tony knows about Brenda's affair with John Beaver, which all of London knows about by now.

Tony rues his decision to make the surprise visit and complains that he doesn't get along with Brenda's new circle. He reflects with disbelief on her apparent commitment to studying economics, under which guise she's been spending most of her time in London. He says that after much thought, he's come to realize that Brenda may have been bored at Hetton. Jock feels low as well, due to trouble with his constituents over pork farming laws, and the two continue to drink a great deal. Tony invites Jock to Hetton the next weekend, lamenting how he never sees his old friends anymore.

A call arrives from Brenda, but it is John Beaver impersonating a butler and telling Tony that Brenda is very tired and cannot see him at all tonight. Quite drunk by this point, Tony calls back and insists on coming to the flat, while Brenda pleads with him not to. She then telephones Jock and instructs him to prevent Tony from coming by the apartment, but she sends Beaver away anyhow as a precaution. Tony and Jock go on a drunken spree to the Old Hundredth, a seedy nightclub in an ethnic neighborhood that has survived generations of attempts to shut it down. At the club, two prostitutes named Milly and Babs make their acquaintance, and the staff take advantage of their inebriated customers by selling them food they didn't order. Tony makes numerous drunken phone calls to Brenda, disturbing her all night.

The next day, Tony is hungover and ashamed. Brenda is secretly thrilled, because Tony's guilt over his behavior will keep him from prying further. Back at Hetton, John Andrew meets Tony at the train station and enthusiastically bombards him with questions about his trip to London. Tony has no good answers, since he didn't even see Brenda, and he loses his patience and hurts the boy's feelings. John Andrew begins holding a grudge against his father. All evening, Tony remains wracked with shame about his conduct the night before. He finally goes to bed in Brenda's empty room.

Jock diplomatically handles an uncomfortable situation by playing dumb about Tony's cuckoldry and joining in his drinking binge. By this point, Tony can tell something is wrong in his marriage, but there is still no sign that he's suspected his wife's affair—with anyone, much less the detested Beaver.



The sadness of Tony's situation now comes to light, as he reckons with the fact of his formerly serene marriage faltering for reasons he can't understand. He finally realizes that Brenda has been bored at Hetton—an obvious conclusion. His tardiness in reaching it reveals his naivete and failure to pay adequate attention to his wife. With Brenda around less and less, Tony now begins to experience the loneliness that she had been feeling at Hetton.



The sordid sequence of Tony's night displays the floundering helplessness to which Brenda has reduced him. His repeated failed attempts just to get in touch with his wife are painful to witness, and even more so because it is still not clear that he recognizes that she's having an affair. His situation is helpless because leaving his cheating wife alone will be just as disastrous for him as hounding her. The night likewise exposes the fragility of his posh identity, as a bad mood and a lot of drinks are all it takes to get him elbow to elbow with prostitutes in one of London's most notoriously sleazy nightclubs.



Brenda and Tony's respective reactions the morning after his spree highlight the differences in their moral dispositions. Though he acted irresponsibly, Tony was well justified to be upset with Brenda, but he only feels shame afterward. Brenda, whose behavior caused Tony's reckless spree, immediately sees it as an opportunity to guilt him into accepting her further misbehavior without complaint. John Andrew begins to become a casualty of his parents' faltering marriage.



The next day, Jock telegrams that his weekend visit will have to be postponed. Tony finds himself with little to do by himself at Hetton, only now realizing how much time he used to waste with Brenda. John Andrew continues to hold a grudge against his father, spurning his attempts at reconciliation.

Brenda, meanwhile, leans on Tony's guilt and invites Polly, Mrs. Beaver, and other London friends to Hetton for the weekend. The women immediately begin disparaging the house's architecture in front of Tony and suggesting improvements. Throughout the weekend, Brenda and her friends cackle continuously and subject Tony to numerous minor humiliations. His custom of bringing home buttonhole flowers for his guests on the way back from church earns their scornful laughter, as they'd been betting on what color flowers he would bring.

Brenda begins to worry that Tony will start acting up in response to these indignities and the boredom of life at Hetton without her around, and thereby potentially make trouble for her affair. She thus conspires with Polly Cockpurse to mollify and distract Tony by setting him up with an affair of his own, using her neighbor from the London flat, Jenny Abdul Akbar, as the bait. Invited for the weekend, Jenny comes out strong upon arriving at Hetton in a cloud of musk and exotic furs. She curls up and purrs by Tony's side but mistakes his name for Teddy. Tony finds this vulgar American widow of a Moroccan prince a ridiculous woman, and her weekend of intended seduction at Hetton is a disaster. He does not, however, suspect that Brenda and Polly were putting Jenny up to the job.

John Andrew, on the other hand, seems to experience a sexual awakening when Jenny greets him with a kiss on the lips. Thereafter the boy is quite enamored of her, asking her endless questions about her exotic appearance and mysterious past. Brenda and Polly ruefully admit that their plan has failed. Meanwhile, Brenda's disregard for Tony becomes increasingly pronounced, with less and less effort put into her cover story of studying economics.

Tony does not need to work for a living. Brenda's absence makes apparent for the first time the silliness with which he was accustomed to filling up his days. To boot, John Andrew no longer wants anything to do with him either.



For Tony, who detests company, this weekend gathering of Brenda's vapid socialite chums is his worst nightmare. Brenda has been part of his world of quaint and affectionate rituals like gathering buttonhole flowers since the beginning of their marriage, but now she is willfully disrupting it and exposing it to mockery. Tony silently endures the indignity of his loathsome guests.



Brenda's recognition that her openly disdainful treatment of Tony and Hetton may be going too far seems to indicate a degree of conscience on her part. However, her response of trying to sidetrack him with his own affair indicates two things: first, that she only thinks about Tony's feelings out of preemptive self-interest; and second, that she can only conceive of a plan based on what would work on her. It predictably fails miserably on Tony, and the whole fiasco calls into question how well she really knows Tony at all, and how their marriage functioned smoothly for as long as it did.



John Andrew's infatuation with Jenny indicates that he has been starved for affection in the months since his parents' marriage has started to fray. It simultaneously underscores the boy's ongoing natural rejection of the prim class etiquette standards that Tony, who finds Jenny vulgar and distasteful, has internalized.



Brenda invokes her fictitious economics course to excuse herself from the upcoming fox hunt at Hetton, a grand annual tradition. The weekend before the hunt, Brenda invites Jock, Marjorie, and Marjorie's husband Allan to Hetton, and Tony enjoys the company. Brenda devotes the whole weekend to Tony, making him glad as she accompanies him to church and other habitual outings. Tony sleeps in bed with Brenda for the first time in a long while, and he raises doubts about the health of their marriage, saying that her being away so much makes him wonder if she's being unfaithful. Brenda reassures him that their marriage is fine. Meanwhile, all their guests independently speculate about whether the other guests know about Brenda's affair.

Tony convinces Jock to stay down for the fox hunt and invite his girlfriend, Mrs. Rattery, mysteriously dubbed "the shameless blonde." She arrives at the wheel of her own propeller plane. She speaks little and enjoys masculine activities, as well as extended solitaire sessions. Tony is surprised, as he had expected Jock's girl to be a garrulous bimbo.

The day of the great fox hunt arrives, and John Andrew has been eagerly anticipating it for weeks. The whole community takes part, and Tony permits John Andrew to ride along on Thunderclap within a certain limit—much to the nanny's chagrin, who thinks poorly of the whole hunting affair. On the ride out, they pass Miss Ripon from the village barely controlling a frantic and unwieldy horse that her father has been trying for some time to get rid of for an unfair price. When the stipulated limit is reached and no foxes found, Ben Hackett reluctantly insists that he must take the devastated John Andrew home, while Jock proceeds with the hunt.

On the road back, they encounter Miss Ripon and her steed again. She had been tossed from the horse and injured. While they wait with her in the road for a horse trailer to take the animal away, a stopped motorcycle backfires and startles the horse. The steed kicks, knocking John Andrew off his saddle, then striking the boy again into a ditch and killing him instantly. All quickly agree that no one is to blame.

In keeping with her self-interested attempt to lure Tony into an affair, Brenda again recognizes that some kind of appeasement is necessary for Tony in light of her skipping the fox hunt. She thus treats him affectionately, like she used to, for a whole weekend. The reader is treated to the ironic juxtaposition of the naïve Tony finally raising a timid question about their marriage's health to Brenda, which she quickly dismisses, while everyone else in their house talks knowledgeably about her affair.



Mrs. Rattery acts as a foil to the predatory, status-obsessed women that have featured in the plot so far. Her laconic "masculine" nobility likewise shows up Tony's relative spinelessness. His low expectations for her also hint at his prejudicial lack of interest in women, as displayed in his treatment of Brenda early in the novel.



Tony overrides the disapproving Nanny to allow John Andrew to join the fox hunt, suggesting that the father-son relationship is on the mend. Throughout the novel, Ben Hackett seemingly takes a more active interest in John Andrew than Tony does, but his reluctant observance of Tony's designated limit serves as a reminder that he is ultimately Hetton's employee.



That John Andrew had to plead so hard to be allowed to participate in the fox hunt, and that he dies in a random accident while being sent home rather than in a glorious hunting chase, makes his death both ironic and all the more tragic. The fact that there is no obvious person to point fingers at only amplifies the feeling of senselessness.



As the hunting party laments the tragedy, Tony's first thought is to get the news to Brenda. Jock volunteers to go to London and tell her in person. Tony is in disbelief but calmly begins setting about the necessary arrangements. He diplomatically handles bothersome well-wishers like Rev. Tendril. Tony has no desire to talk about religion in this challenging time, although, as Mrs. Rattery says, "some like it." He appreciates Mrs. Rattery's decision to stay with him while Jock is gone. She suspends judgment on Tony's confident assertion that the news will grieve Brenda, saying, "You can't ever tell what's going to hurt people." Tony obsesses over the time of day, repeatedly speculating whether Brenda has been informed yet. Mrs. Rattery successfully distracts him with the only card game Tony knows: Animal Snap, which involves the two of them making animal noises. The butler sees this behavior and is mortified.

Jock finds Brenda's flat empty, but Jenny Abdul Akbar appears in the hall. Hearing the news about John Andrew, she bewails her cursed fate as a bringer of evil. Yet she quickly puts these histrionics aside and leads Jock to Brenda at Polly's house. There, the bogus psychic Mrs. Northcote is reading the ladies' fortunes, giving the same vague predictions to them all in private. Brenda keeps steering her reading towards information about John Beaver. Jock arrives and tells her there's been a fatal accident, confirming it when Brenda asks, "John?" When Brenda realizes it was John Andrew and not John Beaver, she blurts out "Oh thank God" before bursting into tears. Later, as she packs her bag at the apartment to return to Hetton, she tries to tell Jock that she was delirious when she said that, but he is unconvinced. He sees her off to the train.

At Hetton, Tony handles the inquest and gets the necessary affairs in order. Ben gets Tony's approval to sell Thunderclap. Brenda returns, and she and Tony agree that there is nothing to be said. And yet, Brenda shocks Tony by keeping to her old plans to spend the weekend at a friend's house—much to the friend's embarrassment. Brenda tells Tony that their life at Hetton is all over, leaving him dumbfounded.

Tony invites Jock to Hetton for the weekend and tries to rationalize Brenda's going away, but at the friend's house, Brenda tells John Beaver she loves him. She then states as much in a brief letter to Tony that also clarifies she won't return to Hetton. Tony is shocked, still completely clueless about Brenda's affair. Jock must tell him that everyone except Tony has known for some time.

Tony's almost muted reaction to the news of John Andrew's death, followed by his nervous fixation on the time, are classic signs of shock. His impatience with religious talk at this moment of death and crisis reveals that his habitual churchgoing was not connected to any genuine religiosity. His only concern at this point is informing Brenda and anticipating her reaction. Mrs. Rattery again acts as the model of stoic masculinity. Her ominous remark foreshadows Brenda's reaction not being quite what one would expect from a mother. The game of Animal Snap creates a moment of grim, surreal humor amidst the senseless tragedy.



Jenny's reaction to the news brings out her absurd self-centeredness, in contrast to Jock, who has volunteered for a very serious task in order to help his friend Tony. The fortune-telling party at Polly Cockpurse's is of course a carnival of narcissistic delusion, as well as gullibility. Ironically, Brenda has her sham fortune reading interrupted by genuinely fortune-altering news. Her kneejerk reaction makes explicit the damning revelation that has been heretofore implied: she cares more about her odious boytoy John Beaver than her own son, and is relieved to hear that the latter, not the former, has died.



Tony continues to maintain his composure as the sad silence following a death sets in. He was not, however, prepared for the speed and conviction with which Brenda casts off the remaining trappings of her and Tony's marriage, which embarrasses even her friends.



Clearly, Tony has been naïve about Brenda's affair for a long time by now, but Brenda's departure is so bizarre that he is justified in trying to explain it as a symptom of shock. Meanwhile, John Andrew's death has liberated Brenda to declare her true feelings for Beaver.



CHAPTER 4: ENGLISH GOTHIC—II

Tony rides out the sudden separation at Jock's house for a few weeks, avoiding Brat's club for fear of running into John Beaver and frequenting Brown's club instead. Friends try unsuccessfully to comfort Tony and play peacemaker. Marjorie and Allan attempt to convince him that this is only a phase and that Brenda will soon come running back into his arms, but Tony insists that he doesn't want her back. He has only one brief **phone** call with Brenda, who denies Allan's downplaying of her affair and reaffirms her refusal to return to Hetton. She seems as bored with Tony as ever. Brenda's friends swear to stick by her side no matter the outcome.

Through intermediaries, Tony receives Brenda's verbal agreement on an acceptable sum of 500 pounds for an annual alimony, and due to legal custom of the time, he agrees to set her up as the plaintiff. This involves incriminating himself by hiring a law firm to collect staged evidence of him "cheating." Jock suggests they return to the Old Hundredth, the nightclub from their drunken spree. There they arrange for Milly, one of the same prostitutes they met on that night, to accompany Tony to the seaside resort town of Brighton to stage his infidelity. Tony unambiguously refuses Milly's suggestion that she bring along her young daughter, Winnie. Nevertheless, after Tony passes a sleepless night wondering where he went wrong in his marriage, Milly arrives at the train the next morning with Winnie in tow. Tony is forced to allow her along to avoid making a scene.

Nothing about the weekend at the seaside hotel goes according to plan: the unshakeable brat Winnie's presence confuses the hotel staff and jeopardizes the whole premise of a supposed illicit getaway, as the detectives Tony has hired to get photos of him make clear. These detectives, however, aren't exactly filling Tony with confidence as he spots them drinking champagne on his dime.

During the weekend, Milly recognizes her old client Dan, who invites them along to his friend's party, to the displeasure of his nagging wife. The next day, Winnie makes Tony buy her breakfast, but the detectives intrude to remind him that he needs to be seen having breakfast in bed with Milly for the sake of evidence. Later, Winnie makes Tony take her for a walk on the beach. When he won't let her swim in the freezing water, she yells about his two breakfasts, and the whole scene convinces onlookers that Tony is insane.

Brenda's abandonment of Tony ironically brings them closer together geographically, as Tony migrates to London to escape the depressing atmosphere at Hetton. However, their physical proximity does nothing to overcome their actual remoteness: they continue to communicate only through interlocutors and the telephone. Brenda's cheery heartlessness seems totally undimmed by John Andrew's death.



Tony's willingness to go along with this self-incrimination scheme so that his wife can divorce him is cringeworthy: sheer habit and naivety make him unthinkingly accept second-hand reports of a verbal agreement from a woman who has already betrayed him. The setup strongly foreshadows disaster for Tony. Meanwhile, the calamities of recent weeks have still not managed to provide Tony any insight into the root problems in his marriage.



The indignities Tony is subjected to compound over the weekend, as his situation's absurdity multiplies exponentially with the ridiculous presence of his prostitute's child. The detectives are just as keen to take advantage of his money and manners as Brenda turned out to be.



Tony's presence at a wild party at some seaside hotel, with a prostitute and a man he just met, would have been unimaginable just a few weeks earlier. The scene highlights how swiftly his life has fallen apart. Tony probably regrets all the times he lost his patience with the merely enthusiastic John Andrew, faced now with a genuinely awful child whom he cannot reprimand.



Back in London, Brenda's solicitor confidently remarks to Brenda that they now have all the evidence they need, and he encourages her to tell sob stories about Tony's mistreatment of her in court. When Tony returns to London, Brenda's clumsy and eccentric brother Reggie, an amateur archaeologist, goes to meet with him at Brown's club. He suggests that Tony wait for Brenda to come back, for which Tony says he has no desire. Reggie counters with a string of trumped-up character blemishes and then gets to the point. Brenda's verbal agreement was meaningless; she demands 2000 pounds annually, which would force Tony to sell Hetton. When Tony refuses, Reggie invokes the Brighton evidence that Tony himself staged as a sure case-winner for Brenda if it came to court.

Tony, in disbelief, **calls** Brenda, who confirms Reggie's words: she hadn't originally thought to renege on their verbal agreement, but John Beaver gave her the idea. Tony hangs up and feels a flash of lucidity, as the fantasy world he had mentally inhabited for so long seems to crumble: "[a] whole Gothic world had come to grief..." Tony returns and tells Reggie that Brenda will not get a cent: Winnie's presence throughout the whole weekend at Brighton proves his fidelity. He announces his plan to take a 6-month voyage abroad, to be followed by a divorce with no settlement whatsoever. Brenda's friends are shocked by the news.

Predictably, Brenda's verbal alimony agreement turns out to have been a total farce and a trap that Tony walked straight into. It seems that Brenda genuinely has no scruples at all: she is willing to lie wholesale about Tony's character in court, and it means nothing to her that her extortionate alimony demands would force Tony to sell his ancestral home. She cannot even be bothered to tell Tony this herself; she has her preposterous brother Reggie deliver the news.



Brenda adds some crucial context to the picture being painted by Reggie: John Beaver is really behind the drive to extort Tony for all he's worth. Brenda, however, happily goes along with this plan, indicating how in thrall to Beaver she is. Tony's sudden disillusion sets up his startling rejection of Brenda's terms with an ironclad defense, his first moment of real self-assertion in the novel so far. Winnie's unbearable presence that weekend ironically turns out to save Tony.



CHAPTER 5: IN SEARCH OF A CITY

Tony is on a drab midsize vessel setting out from England. To an overly conversational fellow passenger asking about his destination, Tony replies that he's looking for a city. The passenger thinks he's crazy, but later apologizes, saying he hadn't realized that Tony is actually an explorer. Tony reflects on how he got here, leaving England for one of the few times in his life: just two weeks ago, he was casting about listlessly for ideas at a travel agency, looking to go anywhere far away from Brenda, John Beaver, and Hetton, which for the moment was only a source of bitterness to him.

One afternoon, Tony was approached at a dining club by the eccentric explorer Dr. Messenger. Messenger informed Tony of his upcoming expedition to Brazil in search of a lost, glorious City in the Amazon, mentioned in various legends. Messenger seems to have detailed leads on the city's possible whereabouts, speculating that it lies in the territory of the Pie-Wie Indians. Though a totally inexperienced traveler, Tony enlists with him on a whim. On board, he has vivid fantasies of the City as remarkably Hetton-like.

The sudden change of scenery underscores the sudden and drastic change of outlook that Tony has just undergone. Realizing that he's lived his whole life within limited horizons, and simultaneously wanting to flee the toxic atmosphere lingering around his life in England, he doubles down on his strong rejection of Brenda's demands with an equally bold journey to unknown lands.



The proposal for Tony's journey is almost unbelievable, which perhaps was why he chose to embrace it. It seems that he finally wants to break free of the familiar habits that have defined his whole, bland existence, and sees an opportunity to do so in the most un-Tony proposition imaginable. However, his habits quickly overrule his imagination, and Hetton reasserts its primacy for him.



Amidst the weeks-long boredom of life at sea, while Dr. Messinger remains in his cabin with seasickness, Tony strikes up a romance with fellow passenger Therese de Vitre, an 18-year-old Trinidadian girl from a rich family. She's taken with Tony's status as an explorer, and he expounds on the dangers and difficulties of his upcoming journey. She regales him with tales of her home, where life is easy for the island's few aristocrats. Tony quickly spoils the brief romance by revealing that he's married. The ship reaches Trinidad and Therese disembarks quickly without much thought for Tony.

Tony and Dr. Messinger disembark at Demerara. They assemble supplies, a boat, and six Black hired hands. They then take to the river and set off upstream, well past the furthest trading outpost and inland into the heart of the jungle. Insects and unfamiliar noises assail Tony incessantly; sores, scratches, and bites proliferate all over his body. Dr. Messinger is more accustomed to the jungle surroundings and reprimands Tony for constantly scratching his bites. And yet, while sleeping, Messinger is bit by a vampire bat.

Tony reflects on the time change and speculates what may be going on in England at that moment. He remembers his days of courting Brenda. The narrative briefly pivots to Jock and Brenda, dancing at a party in London. Brenda mentions that John Beaver seems to be growing tired of her, and that her divorce cannot proceed without word from Tony. She wonders whether Tony is safe on his harebrained expedition, and Jock reassures her that "the whole world is civilized now."

Tony and Dr. Messinger arrive at a village of Macushi Indians, where only women are present. Messinger tries communicating in Wapishiana and is surprised that they can't understand him. One of them, Rosa, speaks English and clarifies that their tribe doesn't speak Wapishiana. She explains that the men are gone for the next three days on a pig hunt, and then she demands cigarettes. Back at Westminster, Jock, a member of parliament, reads a long-prepared but trifling request on pig-farming legislation to an under-secretary of the Minister of Agriculture. He leaves feeling proud of having served his constituents.

Tony's uncharacteristic behavior continues to provoke a stream of unexpected new developments: a fun, spontaneous affair with a young foreign girl would not have been conceivable for him a month ago. Once again, however, his self-defeating attachment to the familiar blocks his path: he could easily have just not mentioned his marriage, but this does not even occur to him.



The reckless and romantic decision to cast his lot with a harebrained Amazonian expedition is no longer the abstraction it was while on board ship. The mission has suddenly become very real, and the harsh realities of the alien environment are quite severe. The vampire bat seems to literalize the metaphorical bloodsuckers that surrounded Tony back in England.



The narrative moves back and forth between England and the Amazon, juxtaposing Tony's increasingly inhospitable surroundings with Brenda's similarly growing difficulties. Jock's "civilized" comment is ironic because not only is Tony totally removed from civilization, but England's own degree of "civilization" has come into question in the course of the novel.



The extent of Messinger's preparedness for this expedition begins to come into question in this encounter. The narrative once again juxtaposes Amazonian "barbarism" and English "civilization" to bring out the commonalities between them. Despite the baroque bureaucratic architecture they've erected to handle the problem, the English just as much as the Macushi are simply men hungry for pigs.



When the Macushi men return, they have a drunken week-long feast. Finally, they sober up, but they are reluctant to join Dr. Messinger's search for the Pie-Wie people, whom the Macushi dread. Eventually, Messinger succeeds in negotiating for 12 men and 7 of their wives to join and guide his expedition. The Macushi celebrate the agreement with another three-day binge. At last, they send the Black hired hands back downstream, leave a cache of provisions in the village, and set off again. Dr. Messinger proudly tells Tony that maps are useless henceforth.

Back in London, John Beaver fails to get elected into Brown's social club, an effort for which he was relying on Allan and Reggie's endorsement and support. He responds by displaying coldness to Brenda, whose own social stock has also fallen. His reaction upsets Brenda, who has begun to survive off sandwiches ordered from the corner deli as she spends two or three days at a time in bed. Even Jenny Abdul Akbar is now getting invited to more social events than Brenda. Mrs. Beaver is disappointed with the way things seem to be shaping up for her son. She decides to bring him along on a holiday in California in the coming summer.

For weeks, Dr. Messinger and Tony march deeper into the jungle, losing their bearings and struggling to communicate with their guides. Dr. Messinger's confident assessments of the topography are repeatedly proven wrong. The land becomes more arid and desolate, and water grows scarce. Tony and Dr. Messinger rarely speak to one another due to their constant exhaustion. The mosquitoes are relentless around their camp. Tony and Messinger instruct the Macushi women to fan them away as they rest, but as soon as they fall asleep, the women abandon their post, and they awake covered in bites. The Macushi claim there is no game in this region, but Messinger speculates that they refuse to hunt out of fear of the Pie-Wie Indians.

Dr. Messinger resolves to have canoes made and travel down a nearby stream, since he calculates that the Pie-Wie City must be downstream of them. While the men are put to work on the canoes, Messinger and Tony spend the time guarding their sugar supplies from the Macushi women. After several days, the Macushi finish the canoes, but Rosa tells Messinger that they will not accompany him downstream. She repeatedly insists that the Macushi people and the Pie-Wie people do not mix. Bribes of cigarettes, and threats, are fruitless: Rosa and the Macushi will not budge, insisting on returning to their village. Messinger calls them cowards, but now Rosa says that they must return for the cassava harvest.

It is telling that Dr. Messinger never inquires why the Macushi fear the Pie-Wie people; he merely chalks it up to stubborn superstition. The uselessness of maps after a certain point in their journey encapsulates the unprecedented conditions of Tony's life in recent months. Tony, for his part, remains mostly silent throughout this portion of the journey, keeping any doubts or complaints he may have to himself.



Beaver's interest in Brenda fading as her financial lines and ability to open social doors for him dries up was totally predictable; he never seemed to even try to reciprocate her affection. And yet, with Tony gone, this fraying relationship leaves Brenda in an increasingly desperate social situation, with less and less contact with the women she considered her friends.



Dr. Messinger's stated expertise grows increasingly doubtful, but Tony still raises no objections. Messinger's vanity with regard to the Macushi continues unabated. The women's refusal to continue swatting mosquitoes away from Tony and Messinger while they sleep exposes the men's vulnerability: they cannot punish the women with force, because they need them, whereas the Macushi don't need the explorers at all.



By this point, there is no real reason to believe Messinger's geographical calculations, but no one else has a better idea, so the canoe plan goes ahead. He and Tony, of course, don't take part in the arduous construction. Messinger's ignorance will not be reasoned with by any amount of Macushi explanation. Unfortunately for him, this means that he has hit a brick wall: he has no leverage on Rosa and the Macushi, only some novelty goods that they would like but can easily live without.



Finally, Dr. Messenger—claiming, “I know the Indian mind”—unveils a wind-up, green-and-white mechanical mouse and sets it ticking. The Indians are horrified and flee instantly. Night falls, but Messenger remains confident they will return. They do indeed return that night, noiselessly retrieving their scattered tools and then vanishing again, permanently. Back in London, John Beaver and Brenda eat breakfast at a restaurant after partying all night. Beaver reflects wistfully that the partygoing season is drawing to a close. Brenda asks him to pay, and he complains about the prices. He confirms that he’s heading to California soon with Mrs. Beaver, which spells the end of his and Brenda’s relationship, despite her apparent attempts to convince him to stay. She tells Beaver he shouldn’t bother to walk her home.

Tony and Dr. Messenger paddle on alone, hazardously and inefficiently, still spotting no signs of human life. The minimal supplies they decided to keep are still dangerously overloading the craft. Their journey at this stage is slow but peaceful, until Tony develops sudden and severe fever. The fever waxes and wanes in intensity, but it nevertheless majorly hampers their progress. Tony wants to wait and recuperate onshore, but Dr. Messenger insists that they paddle on.

Tony begins hallucinating: Brenda appears, nonsensically recycling fragments of speech and incident from throughout the novel. As he talks to her over the next day and a half, Messenger realizes how sick Tony is and sets up a “temporary emergency base camp.” The next day, Messenger explains to Tony that he’s seriously ill. He sets off alone downstream to find help for Tony but is sucked over a waterfall and killed.

Back in London, Brenda visits the family solicitor in desperate need of money, but he explains that Tony explicitly instructed not to give Brenda anything in his absence, and that Tony’s presumptive heirs are his cousins, the family of Richard Last. Brenda can’t believe that Tony meant to stay abroad for as long as he has, but her legal resources in the situation seem to be nonexistent. Later, in the flat, she cannot muster the will to feed herself with the meager food she has procured. She breaks down crying about all her friends abandoning her. John Beaver, Jock, Marjorie, Allan, Polly Cockpurse, even Jenny Abdul Akbar: all of them are off enjoying varied and fabulous summer vacations, while she lies miserable in bed.

Meanwhile Tony, alone, dozes at the camp in delirium. In a brief moment of lucidity, Tony recognizes that he’s too weak to feed himself, and he begins to cry. Later, he tries to refill the kerosene lamp but knocks over the oil keg, causing him to cry again. Soon, the fever returns.

Messenger’s vanity finally does him and Tony in: his bizarre deployment of the toy mouse was perhaps intended to exploit some known feature of local mythology, since it does provoke such a strong reaction—just not the one he wanted. They have run out of options to convince the Macushi to stay on with them. Meanwhile, the Amazon-England parallels continue, as Brenda has similarly run out of ways to make Beaver stay with her. Beaver is as cheap and unpleasant as ever, and his opportunistic abandonment of Brenda is as unsurprising as the Macushi’s of Tony and Messenger.



With the Macushi gone, Tony and Messenger’s prospects have grown bleak. Tony’s fever only compounds the dire outlook for their mission. The search for the elusive lost City still nominally remains their goal, but at this point, simple survival would probably be welcomed, as it no longer looks guaranteed.



The hallucinations brought on by Tony’s fever provide a capsule summary of the chaos into which his life has been plunged. His reckless attempt to escape his life in England has not worked, as thoughts of it continue to torment him. Messenger’s death, the second in the novel, seems to spell certain doom for the fever-bound Tony.



As Tony languishes beyond contact in the Amazon, talk of his potential demise finally begins to air in London. Tony’s adamant rejection of Brenda’s extortionate demands was no mere show, it turns out: he has ensured that even his death will not let Brenda get her hands on his wealth. Brenda’s situation is now totally abject. Just as one might have imagined, John Beaver and her ruthless socialite friends have totally lost interest in her since her money has dried up. Yet Brenda still does not seem to accept any responsibility for her change of fortune. She rather sinks into unreserved self-pity.



Tony’s conditions again directly parallel Brenda’s in London: like her, he is too weak to feed himself and collapses in a flood of self-pity.



Tony's fever completely takes over his consciousness, subjecting him to a hallucinatory trial where the characters and events throughout the novel get nightmarishly refracted and redistributed at random. Reggie, Winnie, the Hetton butler, Mrs. Rattery, and others all appear before him in a terrifying phantasmagoria. Finally, he imagines that he's approaching the City after all: it rises up before him in total neo-Gothic splendor. The gates are thrown open, trumpets hail his arrival, and everything is as beautiful as Hetton.

As Tony succumbs to a horrifying chaos formed out of his own past, the final image of him arriving at a splendid Amazonian twin of Hetton is meant to be ambiguous: has Tony died? Or is this just a further delusion? If still alive, his prospects for making it out of the jungle seem at this point nonexistent.



CHAPTER 6: DU CÔTÉ DE CHEZ TODD

Miraculously, Tony struggles through the jungle until he stumbles onto the remote ranch of Mr. Todd, an English-speaker. He arrives extremely ill, still hallucinating wildly and spewing about his fevered visions. Mr. Todd administers a foul-tasting concoction to Tony, who soon cries himself to sleep in a hammock. Slowly, Mr. Todd nurses him back to health, explaining the vast medicinal resources contained in the jungle for those who know how to use them. Tony learns that Mr. Todd's mother was an Indian but his father was a missionary from Barbados, and that most of the Indians on this complex are Mr. Todd's children. For this reason, and because he has a gun, they obey him.

Tony has somehow managed to stay alive. His chance arrival at the jungle ranch of an English speaker is almost as fantastical as if he had actually found the City. Just as the irritating presence of Winnie during his weekend with Milly turned out to save him from Brenda's extortion scheme, it looks like Tony may once again have found salvation in the unlikely of places. Mr. Todd's mention of his gun, however, strikes a note of menace in the situation in which Tony, barely alive and totally powerless, now finds himself.



They converse more as Tony's strength recovers. Mr. Todd asks him if he believes in God, and Tony says he never really thought about it. Mr. Todd, who cannot read, shows Tony his complete collection of Dickens, which his father used to read to him. After his father's death, Mr. Todd was read to by a Black English-speaker who passed through the area, whose grave is now on the property. Mr. Todd is very pleased that Tony can read, and he declares that Tony will read to him.

In the midst of another extended crisis, Tony again affirms religion's irrelevance for him. Mr. Todd's father was a missionary, and his question presumably implies that he himself is religious, but he doesn't pry into Tony's position or bring up religion again.



Mr. Todd adores Dickens, finding an inexhaustible well of delight in the novels even after hearing all of them read several times, and Tony at first enjoys reading Dickens's works to him. The activity reminds him of how he would read aloud to Brenda in the first year of their marriage, until Brenda finally blurted out that she couldn't stand it. Then, John Andrew became his captive audience. But the novelty of this new arrangement with Mr. Todd soon wears off, and Tony begins to detect a menace in Mr. Todd's demeanor. Mr. Todd deflects about the possibility of Tony leaving, offering conflicting excuses: first, he says he must wait for the rains to raise the river to navigable height; then when the rains come, he says the Indians will not build boats during the rainy season out of superstition.

The complete set of Charles Dickens, the ultimate symbol of sentimental English culture, makes Tony's encounter with Mr. Todd's ranch even more poetic and ironic. Modern England disappointed Tony by not living up to his sappy Dickensian conception of it—and as in Brenda's case, rejecting his boorish imposition of this fantasy. He flees his disenchanted homeland in search of a lost City, but here in the Amazon, he finds rather the foundational textbook for that fantasy. Meanwhile, Mr. Todd's ominous behavior begins to curdle the sentimental evocation of Dickens's world.



After months of reading, Tony tries to sneak off and enlist the nearby Indians' help, but they merely relay his attempt to Mr. Todd, whose threats that Tony must continue reading now become more explicit. One day, in one of the Dickens novels from which he reads, Tony finds a note written by the Black English-speaker previously on the ranch: it is a promise to release him after he finishes reading aloud the book the note was found in, signed with an X by Mr. Todd. And yet, the man died on the premises. Tony's dread now becomes acute. Mr. Todd tells him he may leave anytime he likes, knowing perfectly well that Tony is powerless to do so without his help.

Eventually, a wayward stranger passes through the ranch, whom Tony manages to entrust with a piece of paper with his name on it before Mr. Todd shoos the man off. One night, Mr. Todd tricks Tony into drinking an intoxicating brew at an uncharacteristic village feast, which causes him to sleep for two days. When he awakes, Mr. Todd explains that while he was unconscious, an English search party arrived looking for Tony, for whom a reward is being offered in England. Mr. Todd sent them away with evidence that convinced them of Tony's death. He now insists that Tony continue reading Dickens aloud.

The discovery of the note from the previous visitor confirms Tony's fear that Mr. Todd has no intention of releasing him. Dickens's works now transform from a lifeline to Tony's sorely missed English culture to a prison ensuring that he will not return to it, barring some radical change in circumstances. Tony's situation is terrifying but inherently humorous: Mr. Todd is like a child demanding another bedtime story, but instead he is the sole, armed ruler of an impossibly remote jungle ranch, with Tony utterly at his mercy.



Yet again, Tony seems poised to snatch victory from the jaws of defeat, with the miraculous appearance of the stranger. But, again, his fortunes turn for the worse, definitively this time, in a missed connection all the more pointedly cruel for being so close to actually seeing him rescued. With emissaries to England now bearing news of Tony's death, his hope of contact to the outside world is dashed forever.



CHAPTER 7: ENGLISH GOTHIC—III

Back at **Hetton**, the estate grounds are in the beauty of spring bloom. Richard Last and his family, Tony's cousins, have made themselves at home there. To cut costs, they have downsized the staff, shuttered several areas of the house, and introduced fox farming on the grounds. Richard and his large family are a jolly, energetic bunch, lacking in both the refinement and the pretensions of Tony and Brenda. They receive a telegram from Brenda, now married to Jock, saying she cannot make it down for the ceremony that day. The family is disappointed but not necessarily surprised. The ceremony is the dedication of a memorial to Tony which reads, "Died in Brazil, 1934." As it turns out, Richard Last was convinced to erect the memorial by Mrs. Beaver, "one of Tony's closest friends," who generously offered to supply the contractors for it. Later that day, Young Teddy, Richard's son, proudly surveys the caged foxes which he imagines will be the means to restore Hetton to its glory days, as it was under his cousin Tony.

The narrative underscores the poignancy of Tony's fate by providing an epilogue where everything back at home seems to be getting along fine without him. Brenda has been happily remarried, to Jock—solving her financial woes, and calling into question the intent behind all the kind deeds Jock did for Tony. Richard Last's vigorous, earthy clan provide a robust counterpoint to both the spineless Tony and the amoral Brenda. As a final insult to Tony, Mrs. Beaver exploits his legacy for cash. The well-meaning young Teddy now supposes that he carries that legacy forward. However, Teddy's enthusiastic farm work both violates the sense of class propriety that for Tony was inextricable from Hetton, and already accomplishes more than Tony ever achieved in his pampered life there. Teddy is both less and more than Tony, and his imagined continuation of Tony's legacy will in fact take Hetton to a very different place.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Cahill, Ciaran. "A Handful of Dust." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 22 Jun 2024. Web. 22 Jun 2024.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Cahill, Ciaran. "A Handful of Dust." LitCharts LLC, June 22, 2024. Retrieved June 22, 2024. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/a-handful-of-dust>.

To cite any of the quotes from *A Handful of Dust* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Waugh, Evelyn. *A Handful of Dust*. Back Bay Books. 2012.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Waugh, Evelyn. *A Handful of Dust*. New York: Back Bay Books. 2012.